

Why Fascism Stems From Ordinary People, Not Monsters (links)

The dark and dirty, disease-ridden and deathly trenches of the First World War were something new in history, a crucible of camaraderie in the face of terrible odds, awe-inspiring new machinery and terrifying weaponry. The trenches were a brotherhood molded by extreme violence. One of these brothers was the German soldier [Ernst Jünger](#). At 19 years old, he sustained over 14 wounds over the course of the war, and when it ended, he could only make sense of it. His experience, he said, if he raised it and gave it some kind of meaning. Jünger died in 1998. He was 102 years old and a respected author, a voice of that lost generation. His 1920 memoir of the war, [Storm of Steel](#), sits apart because rather than just eulogizing the fallen, it heightens the experience of war.

Jünger represents something that runs all the way through this story — the idealizing, glorification, romanticizing, or at the very least, spiritualizing or heightening of violence. He wrote this:

"in these men there lived an element that underscored the savagery of war, while also spiritualizing it — the matter-of-fact joy and danger. The chivalrous urge to fight. Over the course of four years, the fire forged an even purer, even bolder warriorhood."

I've never been near war, but like me, you might be able to understand something small about the old feeling of pride, of bravery, of value that can accompany something negative — a wound, an accident, a challenge, something that's painful. Imagine that. Times a thousand, times a million. Something impossibly difficult in the service of something great. Something transcendent, even. That's what Jünger is getting at. And that's what's key to this story.

Take this passage that he wrote: once again, the ecstasy, the condition of the holy man, of great prophets and of great love is also granted to those of great courage. The enthusiasm of manliness bursts beyond itself to such an extent that the blood boils as it surges through the veins and glows as it foams through the heart. It is an intoxication beyond all intoxication, an unleashing that breaks all bonds. In combat, the individual is like a raging storm, the tossing sea and the roaring thunder. He has melted into everything.

He touches on something that we don't like to admit. We're fascinated by violence. We're culturally hooked on war games, war podcasts, movies and documentaries about war and other types of violence, sometimes gratuitously so. It's as universal as it gets in the human condition, in human history. And Jünger celebrated the declaration of war in the same way many of his young contemporaries did. Bored of routine, of bourgeois life, suspicious of the materialism and the decadence that had spread across Europe and America, desirous of heroism, of something meaningful. Does that sound familiar to you? Could you identify with that? Could you imagine that that might be you too? And this story is for you.

After the war, Jünger said that if the war was meaningless, it would become necessary to give it meaning. He wrote: "the blood of the Great War cannot have flowed for nothing." And in a way, he was right, even if it was a pointless war at the time. Has it not acquired meaning in art, literature, poetry, film, in history itself, over time? This is what we have to reckon with. This is what we have to stare down in our own humanity, in our own souls.

He said that if any type of philosophy saw the slaughter of millions as meaningless, then it must be a barren, nihilistic philosophy in which no God is present. Many of the people we'll meet in this story have very similar ideas — that violence can have meaning because it moves history. It moved Rome, the British Empire, the American Revolution, and many other events, didn't it? It wasn't philosophers or pencil-pushing bureaucrats that moved anything. It was men of action. Aren't we all just a little bit too comfy?

Jünger, like so many, advocated the overthrow of what he saw as a lying, divided parliamentary talking shop. So weak, decadent and lazy. Interwar [Weimar Republic](#). He became part of a clique of writers who were known as the Conservative Revolutionaries in Germany. He advocated for overthrowing democracy and believed in what he called a soldierly nationalism. And it's this soldierly part of nationalism, as we'll see, that becomes so important for fascism. He flirted with Nazism and was mildly anti-Semitic because many people at the time were. He called the early Nazi party revolutionary fire and the Nazis — [Goebbels](#) in particular — loved him, but Jünger stopped short of supporting the Nazis in the end.

So why do I mention him right at the beginning? Because he perfectly epitomizes the complexities of seeing this story through the lens of simple good guys and simple bad guys. Ambiguous people are everywhere here. Ordinary people like you and me. Jünger was a nationalist who hated democracy, but he produced great, authentic, earnest art. Nationalists and people that hated democracy were everywhere in this period. As we'll see, it was the norm. Jünger flirted with fascism, but stopped short of being a fascist.

But the big reason I start with Jünger is the cultural heightening, the idealizing of violence. To think about a violent generation requires a recalibration on our part to understand that violence was a much more ever-present part of life, not just often accepted, but also sometimes thought of as good and purposefully pursued. This is the first mental reversal you have to do to understand fascists from our comfortable screens today. Yes, I see you right now flicking through your phone, bored. You think it's all about being captured by Hitler's spell? Mussolini's propaganda? That you wouldn't be tricked? This interpretation of how you might become a fascist is wrong. You're much more likely to be someone who was already tough, expecting of more war, either experienced or not. Someone who experienced those First World War trenches.

We'll look at many groups that also emerged out of that cauldron of violence, shock troops and veterans, [squadristi](#) and [Arditi](#), those who could use daggers and grenades and hand-to-hand combat, who welcomed close, gritty, tough combat. We'll look at Hitler and Mussolini,

of course, too, and how all of that, combined with a long history of intellectual ideas about the [Volk](#). About socialists and anarchists. About [Darwin and race struggle](#) and much else.

Forget what you know. This is not the story you know. To understand fascism, this narrative has to turn what you know upside down. It's a story in which enlightenment philosophers are evil. Order is sacred. Violent struggles are actually inevitable and progressive. The fascist villains are the heroes. And that Europe has been corrupted by the endless blabbering, patronizing and pontificating of lazy intellectuals and effete parliaments. We're going to go deep into the psychological, historical onion, and you're going to come away from this knowing the fascist, the authoritarian, the warmongering, dictatorial, tyrannical mindset better than anyone. If we're going to understand fascism, we have to look into theirs. And maybe our own souls.

Chapter One: Fertile Soil

In 1914, Germany was by far the most powerful state on the continent. And an emerging middle class looked to more and more years of more and more progress, more prosperity. Where to begin? Well, welcome to Berlin or any other generic big European capital for that matter. I'm going to argue in a minute that this is actually not the first place we should begin, but it does point to something we want to get at. If we can talk of a kind of soul of fascism, an inner core, a foundation, a starting point — where, who or what is that? In a moment we're going to travel to the countryside. And eventually we'll join some Italian squads roaming that countryside looking for some kind of action.

But for a moment, I want to think about the great historian [Richard Evans](#)'s opening line to his Third Reich trilogy. He says, "is it wrong to begin with Bismarck?" [Bismarck](#) ruled over Germany's so-called Second Reich, between 1871 and 1890. He exemplified the ideal of a strong, competent, authoritative, forward-looking, world-shaping but ultimately conservative leadership. That's a lot of words to describe one person, but that in itself, that volume already says something to us about the charisma and the power of a quote unquote strongman.

These types of forward-looking, self-made, i.e. not royal, not hereditary conservative leaders were something new, something old and conservative and new and radical at the same time. A reaction to the idea of the world as progressive, innovative, entirely forward-looking and scientific, entirely radical and moving and revolutionary. A [reaction to the Enlightenment](#). United Germany hated parliaments and division. He was smart, effective, calculating. He negotiated with liberals effectively. He was a kind of revolutionary conservative, or at least a proto-one, a white revolutionary using the past to strongarm the future.

In the 1920s, when the Nazis were rising, many Germans were still alive that lived under and remembered Bismarck. Bismarck had many of the hallmarks of the authoritarian side of fascism. But the key difference amongst many smaller ones was his [elitism](#), that there were

people that politics was meant for, and there were people that shouldn't even be involved, should be anywhere near it. His fear and his rejection of the masses entirely. Hitler and Mussolini's later invention — that innovation — was not to just rule, to control, to preside over the masses, but to accept, to shape, to invite them in to a movement and to use them. He had brought alive the militaristic traditions of Bismarck and [Frederick the Great](#). The Kaiser's dreams of world conquest seemed close to realization.

Bismarck was remembered by Germans as the Iron Chancellor, but his memory had in some ways become distorted. He had to negotiate with liberals, many of whom won concessions like fair trials and equality before the law, a [bourgeois capitalist system](#). The rolling back of most censorship and the acceptance of some parliamentary power. Bismarck, then, was ultimately a [pragmatist](#). He dealt with what was in front of him. Later in 1944, a German diplomat wrote, it's regrettable how false is the picture which we ourselves have created of him in the world. As the jackbooted politician of violence. In truth, his great gift was for the highest diplomacy and moderation. He understood uniquely how to win the world's trust. The exact opposite of today. In this sense, then, Evans could be wrong to start with Bismarck. I think we have to go deeper. And remember, we're not just looking at Germany here.

So where does understanding start? Causes like dominoes. One topples the other. But you can go back too far. One review of books and articles [in the year 2000 counted 37,000 texts on the Nazis](#) alone. And that's before we look at other fascisms. If we're talking anti-Semitism, of course we can go back a long, long way. Maybe you have to look at [Napoleon](#) as the first kind of modern dictator, rather than Bismarck.

And there's a big thing to contend with here — that Italy and Germany were very different places. That France was much more anti-Semitic than Germany. That Italian fascism emerged out of a split from the Italian socialists, that [Hitler hated Marxists as much as he hated Jews](#). Many other countries had fascist or proto-fascist movements, too, as far back as the 19th century. In Russia, the paramilitary [Black Hundreds](#), an ultranationalist, proto-fascist, anti-Semitic group with 3000 branches aiming at mass mobilization, bringing the people in to a conservative movement. France had the anti-Semitic, nationalistic and populist [Action Française](#).

Here's what a lot of these have in common. The 19th century was a new, scary, fast-moving, chaotic, migratory, scientific, [God-is-dead world](#). We also too easily forget how the national and imperial makeup of Europe looked very different. Nations and ethnicities were more scattered and under different empires. Nation states were not the norm in the world. And this idea of being kind of scattered, for lack of a better word, is not something we think about too much today. But countries in Europe were and still are much more porous, much more of a gradient rather than confined in exact borders. Germany, for example, included millions of Poles, some Slavs, Danes, French speakers. The [Austro-Hungarian Empire](#) was made up of dozens of different ethnicities. Think about border towns made up of lots of different ethnicities. It was also much easier to move around — easier, but obviously didn't happen as much. You could cross over borders. Modernity was speeding everything up. You could migrate in a new way.

Bismarck gives us a picture of something many feared during the period. Chaos. Overrunning order. Because of all this. The world was moving fast. The industrial revolution. Capitalism. By the time we get to the turn of the 20th century, electricity, engines, telegraphs, telephones, cars. Planes. Cinemas. Radio. [The second industrial revolution](#). Fascism builds on all of this.

There's also atomization, being uprooted from traditional customs and norms and links in the family, in the church, in the village. There's the fear of decadence and greed, insatiable cities dining on fat portions of exotic foods. Forgetting what it was like to do real work, real fighting. There was a fear of materialism over godliness. There was a fear of the mob over hierarchy.

Bismarck represents a [realpolitik](#), pragmatic, conservative, old-school order and slow and gradual change. That is his [traditional conservatism](#). He had a deep respect for the Prussian monarchy, for the grounded, rooted Junker landed estates and aristocracy, for religion and order ordained by God. It was very, very traditional. But new figures — and we'll get to them — were revolutionary conservatives. They believed in combining the older order with the dynamism and the movement and the inventions and the speed of the future. They were Bismarck on steroids. Napoleon in a tank. [Genghis Khan](#) on the radio.

And in this new and scary and fast period, a few nations were doing very well. Britain. France. America. Slowly, Germany catching up. But that, along with Italy — both countries had something of an inferiority complex. The Franco-Prussian War had proved Germany's military might. But where were her colonies? Italy had the glorious past of Rome. But what of that now? Chaos and nostalgia together. A dangerous combination. The turn of the century was a strange time. Much was smashed together, and many were fearful that the West had become unrooted. Following them on a whim.

Chapter Two: The Pure of the Earth

Okay, now imagine. You're a woodworker in a village. Life's pretty good. Work is pretty regular. You're used to working with the same traditional tools and knowledge and techniques. Generation upon generation. Taught by your dad and his dad before him. You might never have even seen an instruction book or a guidebook. And suddenly factories far away were producing furniture on these production lines. They're being delivered by trains, not just across countries, but across continents. Advertised in national color-printed catalogs managed from a city you've never even been to. With cars. If your tools are obsolete, you will — just the fear of losing your livelihood is due to the upheaval mentally. You're a good person, a farmer, a builder, a grocer. Part of the heartland. The producers. Not that alien, strange, metropolitan type.

In many ways, the strangeness of science, of technology, of mathematics and the Enlightenment, of formal thinking, is the antithesis to all of this. A body of specialist, abstract, esoteric, up there, ethereal, transcendental knowledge by anti-social, distant, awkward men

in [ivory towers](#), intellectuals and technocrats that focus on, I don't know, measuring and categorizing and mathematics, using and studying empiricism with strange new inventions, on rationalism, modernity, bureaucracy, universities, advanced industries, a focus on statistics, abstract numbers, data, how much? What length, what gauge, which measuring beaker, which new microscope? Which industrial instrument, machine cost, demand, supply chain, spending and borrowing and interest rates and loans. All of this stuff to most ordinary people is abstract and far away and I think strangely discomforting, maybe even terrifying.

[Romanticism](#) ended up being a European-wide phenomenon, but in Germany it went deeper and lasted much longer. Romanticism there treated all of this abstract Enlightenment jargon with suspicion. It contrasted those abstractions, that up there, with what was rooted, what was real, down here — bodies, emotion, community, tradition. The English poet [William Wordsworth](#), about as far from a fascist as you might think you can get, said that the man of science seeks truth as a remote and unknown benefactor. He cherishes and loves it in his solitude. The poet singing a song in which all human beings join with him, rejoices in the presence of truth as our visible friend and hourly companion.

This was a general, powerful and revolutionary feeling across Europe and America. Science, philosophy, technology can be seen to many as an exotic, a remote, a strange force — for the opposite of being rooted in a village, community and knowable network of people. If you're a woodworker, yes, of course you measure. You calculate costs, you use some basic maths. Measuring, of course, is central to your work, and always has been. But it's rooted. Rooted in something, to something tangible. Local demand is local demand, right? Local trees and local wood. How do you know all the materials and tools you need? The people, the network. You're less focused on the mathematics and statistics of big national figures. It's about who you know, good relations, contracts with local shops, maybe word of mouth, friends and family in the village. So much that small businesses today still rely on romantic rootedness against Enlightenment ideas and theory and philosophy.

This inspired the German [Völkisch movement](#) of the 19th century. It believed in a people with special characteristics connected in a more than meaningful, almost spiritual, almost religious way to their land, their soil, each other, through language — that there was something unique and immovable about this.

Meet [Friedrich Ratzel](#). He was a geographer and an ethnographer, a measurer, a quantifier, a surveyor of land, of place, and of people, of culture. He was fascinated by different people, by where they lived, and in 1896 Ratzel wrote: "How could you divorce the very being of a nature, a Volk which for half a thousand years has worked, loved, and suffered on the same soil." He coined a term — [Lebensraum](#) — living space, the idea that a people needed space to thrive, to be and to live. He based it on his study of animals migrating, having a territory, protecting that territory, trying to grow that territory. Ratzel wrote that through the German landscape, a people inscribes its spirit and its fate, as it does in its towns and houses. Spirit becomes concrete for Ratzel. The transcendental becomes real.

He was building on this incredibly rich and powerful tradition of [German Romanticism](#). This painting, the [Wanderer above the Sea of Fog](#), or the fairy tales of the [Brothers Grimm](#) who believed that local, real, person-to-person storytelling was as important as Enlightenment rationalism and science, and putting everything in its perfect place. And all of this makes absolute sense, right? Science and maths are just one small, narrow part of life. Life is a jigsaw. You need all of the components. You need community and poetry and connection and religion and culture.

Later, a German writer, [Merlin Ganzervoort](#), put it fascinatingly: "I think like this. A countryside becomes a landscape insofar as it is a coherent whole with its own characteristics. But this can happen only when it becomes the experience of the human soul. If the soul recognizes the rhythm of the countryside in its own rhythm, rootedness is about stable, somewhat predictable structures between all of the elements." This means I am not just includes the elements of countryside, of culture, of music, of art, and of people too.

Völkisch writers in Germany, much like the Brothers Grimm, loved local myths and stories and fairy tales and songs and poetry. They find inspiration in German texts like the [Edda and the Nibelungenlied](#). The Nibelungenlied is an epic Middle Ages German fairy tale of heroism written in 1200, and the Edda is a collection of Norse mythology. And myths are often, I think, misunderstood. The definition of myth is not untrue. Myths are meant to organize [meta-narratives](#). They're meant to provide lessons and stories in the [Jordan Peterson](#) sense. It doesn't matter, or it's not always the point, whether they're true or untrue. They're meant as models for emulation, so a myth could be true. You could provide that model, or they could be fictional or ambiguous. They could be about medieval knights or Jesus or Norse gods, or Marvel superheroes. They could even surround real figures like [Nelson Mandela](#) or [Martin Luther King](#). Myths are larger than life in that they represent a grand story to be told. They act as a kind of glue, and they're meant to entice and guide and teach. In Germany, as we'll get to, they had a particular fondness for this myth.

All of this grew in Germany, in parallel with and as a response to the growth of science, of industry, of capitalism. The end of the century saw a flourishing of [neo-romantic](#) poets and writers and playwrights. This was a Germany-wide cultural phenomenon. Völkisch novels were the most popular novels of the period. Popular tomes like [Helmut Haringa](#), written in 1910, was one of the most widely read novels of the time. The hero had blond hair, moral purity. He was so honest a judge could look at him and know he didn't commit a crime because he had an Aryan face. The young protagonist rejects industrialization and cities and smog and technology and alcohol and racial mixing and horrible built-up urban areas, and instead chooses a pure Völkisch life.

The [Teutoburg Forest](#) was particularly special for the Völkisch writers. The site where an ancient Germanic tribe beat back the all-powerful Romans. A popular novel called Donar followed a Nordic renaissance of a secret group trying to resurrect the cult, whose leader lived in a cave deep inside the Teutoburg Forest. It's full of old Nordic gods and the stories that touch something deep within the German psyche and history, and so were later put on stage by the Nazis.

Many romantic writers had a philosophy of spiritual completeness — that all experiences, the totality of experience, rather than just the singular reason or emphasis on science or doing business, that all things, including emotion and story and community and landscape, evoke — all things make a person's life whole. That without them there will be a lack of spiritual wholeness in the building. Deutscher Meister, wunderbar, englische Wonne — and I think this is very familiar still to us today. It's something I feel very often, and I've been very heavily influenced by the Romantics. I've written articles on the Romantics. I've even been on romantic pilgrimages to Rousseau's birthplace, the Lake District, the Romantics' pursuit of wholeness.

The striving really came from [Hegel's idea of Geist](#), or even further back to [Spinoza](#), that we are part of the universe and that there is an almost total purpose to the universe. The world and everything, including you and me, in it. The philosopher Hegel talked a lot about striving and reaching and dynamism. And I think in some ways there is a kind of insatiability, maybe even a greediness to the idea of reaching completeness, that unstoppable wanting of more and more, not necessarily more money and material things, but spiritual, experiential and cultural things too.

Take [Eugen Diederichs](#). He was a writer that coined the term neo-Romantic in Germany, and he went on to publish an influential magazine called [Die Tat](#) — The Deed — in Vienna, the home of romanticism. The deed, or the act — doing over thinking — this is going to be a really important distinction in what's to come. The idea again, that the Enlightenment and ideas and mathematics and all this kind of ethereal stuff is abstract and above, and the goal is to bring it down to reality, to concrete actions, deeds, doing. This is what's important.

Diederichs made Völkisch ideas respectable when he was a very popular writer, and he was in many ways a model of this kind of aspiring for wholeness, of totality, of a kind of grid of experience. In a way, he was eccentric. He liked exotic things. He wore zebra-skin trousers, a turban, and he hosted ancient Greek wine-themed feasts. The historian [George Mosse](#), in his book on the [Crisis of German Ideology](#), the main book I drew on for this section, says look — for Diederichs, industrial materialism was being opposed by a new spiritual vitality. He thought Germany should renounce liberalism and organize on corporatist lines, where every profession and trade and group and body had its rooted place in an interlocking system.

He wrote that: "my view of God is this — that I regard the sun as source of all life. The rays of the sun represented material infused with Geist, a visible substance transferring invisible heat that God infused." Everything was everywhere. Pantheistic. The swastika, by the way, is meant to be a visual representation of the sun turning, releasing its energy.

Diederichs wrote about and popularized a lot of the Völkisch ideas that had come before him. You can think of the German hero, or anti-hero, right — [Faust](#) — as a model of the man striving and wanting and salivating and needing new experiences, reaching out both for German things and for something more that expands the idea of Germanness. At the same

time. Ich liebe Deutschland, ich liebe die Welt — I love Germany and I love the world. Heimat and then abroad.

There is this kind of strange tension in some of the Völkisch writers, much of it grounded in the traditional, the conservative, the rural and the agrarian, the green. But an interest in improving the greatness by going beyond it — to Hinduism, to India, to the [Nazis' obsessions with the Holy Grail](#). It's an attempt to prove and to reach and to bring in wider experience, greatness and connection, to kind of feed the idea of Germanness and make it bigger.

A paradigmatic example of this is the Völkisch occultist playwright and novelist [Guido von List](#). He was a fascinating, eccentric figure who was obsessed with hidden meanings underneath things. The cult symbols with mysterious powers, special places that could release special forces, and in particular, Germanic spirit. Underneath all this he thought — under the outer surface — that there was a Viking past, a Germanic heritage, an Aryan soul. He thought that it had been overlaid and hidden and buried by Christianity and Judaism, and he wanted to uncover or recover its greatness. Von List said, for example, we must read with our souls the landscape that archaeology conquers with the spade. If you want to lift the veil of mystery of the past, you must fly into the loneliness of nature.

Von List believed in a lost Germanic warrior culture that once ruled Europe, and he believed in a visionary German strongman leader who would come from above and return Greater Germany to its all-inclusive, united greatness. The idea of an Aryan race came from the [discovery in the 18th century that the Indian and European languages had a common linguistic root](#), that they were built on the same structure. The [Indian Rigveda](#) mentioned a [noble Vedic](#) people called the Arya or the Aryans. Von List and others took this to point to a great, noble Aryan race that came from Germany and then moved out as far as places like India. And Italian fascism, as we'll get to of course, looked very similar in a different way. It looked back on the glory of ancient Rome that reached out. But both have this nostalgic greatness at the core, in their early histories — of greatness that's been corrupted. And nostalgia, as we know, is a deeply strange, uncomfortable, but very, very, very powerful feeling.

Von List's ideas were adopted by a man called [Alfred Schuler](#), an influential occultist with a, to my mind, maybe haunting face. He gave talks at a circle in Munich in 1922, which Hitler may have been present at. Schuler led what was called the [Munich Cosmic Circle](#) and further popularized the swastika as a representation, a symbol of an ancient, pure Aryan race that, again, is to be uncovered. We find, we discover and further it. It was a race that was once pure, but had lost its potency over time through the mixing of blood with other races.

Think about linguistics here. This kind of makes sense. French and German would mix on the borders and culture would too. That if you mix lots of paints together, it just becomes brown. It kind of suggests, if you don't know better, that somewhere in a distant past there was some untainted, pure origin to all of this — pure language, pure people, pure culture.

Again, there's a very powerful logic to all of this that underpins it and convinces people of its feasibility, that it might be true.

Christianity doesn't sit very well with [Social Darwinism](#), with struggle and militarism, as we'll get to. And as Christianity became less popular, people searched around for alternatives. It's in this we see a rise in a number of occult and pagan and [perennialist theories](#). Perennialism, meaning that in the past you might find universal clues in lots of different cultures and religions to the inevitability of your universal mission — that you were connected to something in the past that was pure and truthful, and you can see hints of it everywhere. And in this sense, pure equals strength, equals the best, equals Aryan. Symbols like the swastika found in [Pictish caves in Scotland](#) and as far away as India. Influential figures like [Madame Helena Blavatsky, who claimed to have found secret Tibetan texts](#) that hinted at Aryan Eurasian domination in the ancient past, that the Aryans were a pure root race. And the more you can say, look at our great connection to this great and glorious past, the more you can legitimize the claim for great connection to the future, to show your potential, and that everything fits together and is meant to be.

One theme that came out of Völkisch writers again and again was this. That if you have a pure model, a pure German, a pure blood, an ideal, then that assumes logically an opposite, an antithesis — the impure. Anti-Semitism was, of course, a European-wide phenomenon. In fact, it was probably at its worst in France. In most European countries, Jews had different rights and had to often pay different taxes, but these were gradually abolished across the 19th century with Jewish emancipation laws.

The much-discussed Jewish question, which so many European intellectuals and philosophers wrote about and commented on. European Jews had often been banned from the professions and the guilds, which were much more tightly organized in the period. They were over-represented then as financiers, middlemen and merchants to escape this. But because of this they became scapegoats, especially during financial crashes. They became scapegoats for national, for economic and for religious reasons. The wandering enemy within — a very dangerous thing that you can't always see. The opposite of the ideal of Völkisch rootedness.

One of the founders of Völkisch thought, [Paul de Lagarde](#), was both anti-Slavic and anti-Semitic. Lagarde disliked traditional Christianity because of its Jewish influences. He sought to [de-Judaize Christian doctrine](#), which he thought would put it back on track, and he believed that the German Volk should be organized into medieval estates. The Volk should be stable, harmonious with customs and traditions passed down through the German people, but in order, as the German soul was. Jews, on the other hand, were stateless, wandering people. They didn't have any order. They didn't fit into this stable, harmonious vision of German life.

Okay, not all Völkisch thinkers were anti-Semitic. Someone like the philosopher [Moritz von Egidy](#), he believed that the youth had to be educated by Völkisch principles. But on the Jewish question, which was very dominant at the time, he asked: how could the minority of

some half a million Jews in Germany corrupt 50 million Germans? To him it was completely illogical and spoke to something weak of Germany, in the German people, if they could be influenced and corrupted by such a small minority of wanderers on the inside.

In most popular thought, though, there was a reaction to both the [Wandering Jew](#) and the abstractions and destabilization of the Enlightenment and [materialism](#). Rootedness became the key metaphor. And there were these back-to-the-land movements led by thinkers like [Willibald Hentschel](#), for example. [The Artamanen](#) — literally agriculture and man in German — started off as the [Mittgart Society](#) in 1906, and it advocated leaving cities and urban areas and starting back-to-the-land communes. They were basically hippies, but they focused on youth unemployment and became nationalist by their opposition to Polish farm laborers in the East. But many of the groups like this conceived of themselves as being a third way between the idea of communism and capitalism, and they adopted ideas like having Lebensraum. [Himmler](#) was a member of the Artamanen, and it was later incorporated into the Nazi Party.

In 1895, the author [Wilhelm von Polenz](#) wrote a popular novel called *Der Büttnerbauer*, which Hitler said influenced him. In the novel, a peasant borrows some money from a Jew, which he can't repay. He has to then foreclose on the land, and the Jew sells the land to a big industrialist who builds a factory on it, and the novel closes with the peasant himself in front of the factory. The eyes, which were leaving their sockets, stared at the soil. He wrote, the soil to which he had dedicated his life, to which he had sold his body and his soul.

All of this literature and culture saturated Germany. Goebbels, for example, had a [PhD in romantic literature](#). And in this culture and this literature, rootedness becomes a struggle, a struggle to protect and a struggle to preserve or recapture something great. And sometimes rootedness can be the engine of radical expansion. The search for Lebensraum to protect the rootedness. It speaks to something paradoxical about fascism, which we will get back to. It is both backward-looking — at rootedness — and forward-looking — to a kind of radical or even revolutionary conservatism.

I take this quote from Hitler's later so-called secret book, or [Zweites Buch](#), the second book, the follow-up to *Mein Kampf*. Hitler announced that history itself is the presentation of the course of a people's struggle for existence. I deliberately use the phrase struggle for existence here because in truth, that struggle for daily bread, equally in peace and war, is an eternal struggle against thousands upon thousands of resistances, just as life itself is an eternal struggle against death.

Chapter Three: The Science of Struggle

Struggle. Crushing difficulty. Overcoming. Multiplicity. You might notice that one of the organizing factors here are concepts, ideas, phenomena that are relatable to us today, that

make sense to us today, that still exist today. Struggle is, of course, one of them. The struggle of life, something entirely relatable to many of us.

[Max Amann](#), a high-ranking Nazi, later said of Hitler that he takes the view on principle that it's not the job of party leadership to install branch leaders. Herr Hitler takes the view today more than ever, that the most effective fighter in the National Socialist movement is the man who pushes his way through on the basis of his achievements as a leader. Hitler would kind of sit back, watch, let those who struggled past rise to the top themselves. And in some ways, for this reason, historians, as we might get to later, have described him as a [weak dictator](#). He kind of let the machinations of the Nazi party function and revolve underneath him and then only make decisions when he was required to. And this was very deliberately part of Hitler's and the wider Nazi Party's view on the world. And it came from somewhere. And I want you to think about whether this still exists or whether we've changed in some way.

It's difficult to overestimate the effect on people of the discovery of bacteria, microscopic creatures that you can't even see, that can make you ill, that can kill you. [Robert Koch discovered this in 1876](#), in an era already questioning religious belief. Imagine what it was like to suddenly discover there were invisible creatures all around us that make you sick. It changed medicine and it changed people's psychologies. It led to an [obsessive hygiene drive](#), an obsession over cleanliness. In [Jim Crow America](#), adverts showed white people as soap-purchasing clean people and African-Americans as dirty and diseased. This stuff was everywhere at exactly the time Darwin published [On the Origin of Species](Origin of Species). This was a huge, dramatic, psychological and consequential change to how people felt about themselves in the world.

It is particularly important for you to wash your hands after going to the toilet. You see, it is quite possible for you to have germs in your body which don't make you sick at all. But if those germs get from your hands to the hands of someone else, he may not be so able to resist the germs as you are.

The book sent shockwaves around the world. In 1859, [Herbert Spencer](#) coined the term [survival of the fittest](#) — that we are all in a struggle for survival, that we must make ourselves as fit intellectually and physically as possible, because we are competing against each other, against other species, against our environment, and even against invisible organisms on, under, in our skin. Some scholars have pointed to this becoming akin to a European-wide religion at the time, and others have said it pervaded almost all thought across so many disciplines of the period.

Darwin wrote of: "one general law leading to the advancement of all organic beings, namely multiply, vary, let the strongest live and the weakest die. One of the most obvious expressions was that the poor and needy were destined to perish, and the fit and the strong were destined to thrive." But Darwin didn't quite accept this view. He [believed that altruism was compatible with natural selection](#) because it would also improve one's own chances of surviving when and if altruism was then needed, reciprocated towards us. But it didn't really

matter what Darwin thought because many believed this was obvious. This was the clear conclusion. Of course, the sick, the infirm, the weak hold us back in some way.

You know, take the example of a school race that you want to win. What if it was made up of the worst team members? What instead if it was made up of only the elites from around the country? An example of just how pervasive this line of thinking was comes from [War of the Worlds](#), published in 1898, where humans were wiped out by an inferior species. As burned fields and forests and great cities fell before them, huge populations were driven from their homes. A stream of flight rose — it became a giant cemetery without order and without God. It was the beginning of the rout of civilization, of the massacre of humanity.

This was part of the general zeitgeist, the general, widespread cultural fear that rather than stasis, movement, progress, innovation, change means struggle. Compare this to someone like Aristotle, where [everything in the universe has its place](#). Every object, like a stone dropping to the ground, has its place. Or religion, where everything is ordered by God and has its place. In many ways, struggle and dynamism is part of the Enlightenment, part of the [Newtonian view](#) of the world where everything moves. You can see struggle in everyone, from Hegel and Marx to Nietzsche and Dostoyevsky to Darwin and Freud. It is everywhere. [Scientific and pseudoscientific language about race, struggle, pure, impure, blood, hygiene](#) — it penetrated into political and social thought, something we call nowadays as [Scientific racism](#).

Take this later quote from Mussolini himself. He said: "the Socialist Party — and this is when he was in the Socialist Party, by the way, not a fascist — he said the Socialist Party practices expulsions because it is a living organism. There are socialist antibodies, just as there are physiological antibodies discovered by [Metchnikoff](#). If we do not defend ourselves, the impure elements will disintegrate the party in the same way that damaging germs circulate in the blood and kill off the human organism." Mussolini included lots of phrases like this, like the struggle for existence between different parts of the party. It really informed how he thought about the world, politics, social life, and even I think himself from day to day.

Some have even called [Nazism applied biology](#). Others have talked about the [medicalization of human society](#) — using medical analogies, metaphors to describe human life. Take this 1920 speech by Hitler on the Jews. He said that you can't fight a disease without killing the cause, without annihilating the [bacillus](#), and do not think that you can fight [racial tuberculosis](#) without taking care that the people are free of the cause of racial tuberculosis.

In many ways, it was just taking the dominant picture of science, of truth, of objectivity as it was claimed to be, and applying it to everything, applying it to people, to races. All of this ramped up slowly over the previous 70 years. In 1905, the [German Racial Hygiene Society](#) was founded. There was a Venn diagram between Völkisch thought, like the idea of Lebensraum, the special national character, Darwinist survival of the fittest, and of course, colonialism. Struggle meant inevitable war to protect and expand the Volk. Territory was the [ultimate zero-sum game](#).

Hitler's step-by-step plan for world conquest can be summarized this way: conquer Eastern Europe and you dominate the heartland. Conquer the heartland and you dominate the world island. Conquer the world island and you dominate the world. But bacteriology, the influence of Darwin, pointed to the animal kingdom. And again, the objectivity of it. The unignorability of it, the naturalness of it. Territory is all. Strength is all. There are winners and losers. Lions and gazelles, the weak and the strong.

Think about this. We live in an unparalleled period of history. Never before have national borders been so static, defined, agreed upon, with some obvious exceptions right now. But think about Genghis Khan sweeping across the steppe, the British and Roman and every other empire growing or shrinking. Think about how porous, vague, indistinct some ethnic borders are, some national borders all across the world. Think about pilgrims in America. Think about all the people going west and creating lives out there and changing that part of the world. Think about farmers or states or corporations growing, buying more land, thriving.

Thinking in this way was absolutely customary. Normal. Commonsensical. How natural, how inevitable all this was. And you should not or could not rebel against what was natural. You know, of course, all of them needed space. Land for raw materials. Of course, Germany and Italy would fall behind if they gave up and didn't try to catch up with Britain and France. Of course, Italy should be embarrassed by its [defeat by backwoods Ethiopians in 1896](#). These people are the inheritors of the greatness of Rome, the center of Christianity. For Germany's case, the European center of learning, education, sciences, philosophy, the defeat of Rome — both the home of two great European Reichs' glory. Of course, these peoples left behind, but capable of greatness, needed metal, coal, ore, crops, land if they were ever going to secure parity with other great nations. We all deserve a [place in the sun](#).

And neither had the colonies of Britain and France. And Germany had Tanganyika, Namibia, Togoland, Cameroon, New Guinea. The German Empire, the one that existed between unification and the First World War, was slowly growing. Their battle fleet with the aim of keeping up and ultimately beating Britain. A great battle in the North Sea, for example, seemed inevitable to German military commanders. All this rearmament was strictly illegal according to the Versailles Treaty.

Listen to this quote from Mosse about a novel by Willibald Hentschel published in 1907 called [Varuna](#), which was a Völkisch novel about Aryan purity, and Mosse said this: "The course of man's development, Hentschel asserted, was similar to a release of energy potential. History was powered by energy which had been accumulated and stored from the abundant supply of racial dynamism. In primeval times, race was an electric charge. It was dynamic, and it had to be preserved and enhanced by increasing the degree of racial purity."

I find this quite fascinating, and I find a lot of this literature fascinating, because it points to something which — forget that racism didn't have the same negative connotations that it does today — that race and racism in this period were seen by many to be a very positive force, a force central to the development of one's future. As Mosse said, "an electric charge, a dynamic". They didn't have the horrors of the 20th century to look at, to change the

meaning of terms like nationalism and race, like struggle, like purity, like Volk. This was absolutely regular, absolutely expected, normal, mundane, day to day. And all of it infused together — racist thinking with Völkisch, with Social Darwinism — to develop into scientific racism towards the end of the 19th century.

The most influential of these was the English racist thinker [Houston Stewart Chamberlain](#). He had moved to Germany. He was a Germanophile. He was very popular. He was loved by the Kaiser. He talked about the great struggle for supremacy between the German and Jewish races. The Germans, he thought, were a special tribe who had avoided racial mixing. All the great thinkers from the Greeks to Jesus to European artists, were Aryan because of that Euro-Indo linguistic root. Chamberlain said of the Jew that their existence is sin, their existence is a crime against the holy laws of life.

Chamberlain later admired Hitler early on, and when he was dying paralyzed, [Hitler came and visited him and kissed his hand](#). He died in 1927, before the Nazis took power.

Another popular racist was [Arthur de Gobineau](#). He believed that there were three races — white, yellow and black, in that order — and that purity had been diluted by the mixing of them. But he was very pessimistic that anything could change that. Again, like paints muddled together, like entropy. You can't go backwards. He believed mixing had gone too far, but that maintaining what purity was left was key to racial survival.

Once again, this kind of thought comes naturally. What happens if you mix up all of your food? What happens if you scrub your paints together? Mix every note in a song, smash every note on the piano at the same time. What happens if you let your garden just grow? Let all the weeds grow. What happens with racial mixing? Discordance. Disorder. From purity to impurity.

Others, like [Franz Josef Gall](#), believed in phrenology. And the key to phrenology, I'm sure you've heard of it, is this — that an inner essence could be measured through outer appearances, and the purpose of this was that everything could then be classified scientifically and put squarely, statically in its place, organized. One scientist at the time actually invented something called a plastometer, which he claimed could measure the geography of the human face, and in doing so could tell you everything about that person.

So because science brought with it a kind of mystery about the world, if everything could be analyzed and looked at and probed and discovered by empirically looking at the world, by studying it very carefully, if we can find the inner nature of a plant and know where it grows, for example, where to plant it, where an animal belongs, why could we not do the same about humans? If we could find out what their nature was, what their soul was, who they were on the inside, what kind of people they were, what sorts of geography or culture they were suited to, what line of work they were best at, whether they were best at the kind of higher or the lower pursuits, manual labor or intellectual work, leaders or followers. Then you could construct a perfectly simple, rational, ordered utopia where everything was in its place. Perfect order, in one part of the world.

Chapter Four: Enemies of the Volk

What is a city psychologically, with everything imported, with no farmland, no natural order, so much anonymity? A city is a mess. What was a merchant traveling from time to time bringing back alien goods? An alien himself, uprooted. What were the proletariat moving from job to job? Disinherited from the land. What's most of all about the Jews? Homeless, rootless. Not even European, not even Christian, not embedded in a network of Frenchness, not so Germanness. It's not a matter of good or bad. We all know a good Jew. It's a matter of belonging. And Judas has proven his own.

Othering, racism, [tribalism](#) — as old as time. And this isn't the place for a deep, deep history. Well, though, that would be important too. There are wonderful theorists on this kind of thing, like [René Girard](#), who talks about scapegoating in human nature. But I think what's key here is that what distinguishes the new anti-Semitism from the old is its *Völkisch* or sociological and its pseudoscientific component. In other words, it's no longer about religion, or at least it's not about religion alone or in the main. It's a matter of fitting in sociologically, quite literally fitting in the place of things.

As one writer of the Nazi period later said, at a time when the Semites were still searching for the Promised Land and Romulus and Remus were fighting each other, our fatherland already possessed a settled peasant culture. *Völkisch* thinkers would say: The Germans lived in the forest, the deep and mysterious. Because of that, the Jew — they they come from the desert. They are rootless, wandering, shallow and dry. One thinker, [Moses Calvary](#), said that his dreams quite ripened under the pine trees, but not under palms.

Towards the end of the 19th century, in this cultural context that we've slowly led up to, there were a series of depressions and crashes and recessions and crises of capitalism all across the world. The world and in particular the West was changing very quickly. People were displaced. People were migrating more than ever for work, for opportunities, being led by a new kind of globalized mass media, where you could see halfway around the world, where you could dream halfway around the world. Strikes and threats of revolution were increasing. Again, you could see events happening from Australia to America.

But remember, amongst all of this — and this is really key — the majority still lived, settled, rural, mainly agricultural or agricultural-adjacent lives. I often think about the significance of the threat that you can't see — what's in front of our eyes, that we miss or we're used to. We worry about air travel, but not crossing the road, driving to work. And it's easy to scapegoat the person, the threat, the group that are least visible, least present, least able to respond.

If you're in a work meeting about the crisis and John doesn't show up, who's easiest to blame? John. He's not there. He can't fight back. He's not one of the in-group. And for most people, the Jew is the one who is both there and not there, visible in literature and politics and argument in the ballet, but rarely physically visible, especially if you live in the countryside. And it's so easy to define ourselves against what we're not — not black, not

white, English not French, rooted not wandering. The other. The big other is a blank canvas that all of your fears can be projected onto.

We think of anti-Semitism, racism and xenophobia more broadly too, as purely irrational. But I think this blinds us because the tragedy of othering is that there often becomes a kind of logic to it, a dire rationalism. Many Jews, for example, because of their [historic prohibitions and restrictions and the fear of the outsider](#), would be pushed towards — through legal mechanisms and cultural and social ones — being middlemen, being merchants, being quote unquote wanderers, and then becoming department store owners or bankers or living in cities. They were unwelcome in the kind of settled professions. And so they became the stereotypes that were set for them.

The point is — and this is listed in the price of antisemitism article — and so when a [global depression hits in 1873, '84, 1893](#) also called the [Long Depression](#), maybe you need a line of credit for your woodworking materials, for your farm. Maybe the banker is a Jew, or your friend's is. Maybe they extend their line of credit to you. Maybe they deny them or call in loans. Maybe you can't pay. Maybe the bank crashes. Who's really to blame for this crisis?

The stock market in particular was a symbol of some strange capitalism, supposedly dominated by the strange wandering rootless Jews, that seemed greedy and incomprehensible to most ordinary people. And in [1880, there was a national petition to remove Jewish people from government positions](#). Jews were expelled from societies and student bodies. By the turn of the century, anti-Semitism had become so fashionable that one [school boy in 1899 wrote that now a Jew sitting at the same table with a Gentile excites notoriety](#). Accusations of ritual murder became mainstream across these decades. There were 12 ritual murder trials in the Austrian Empire alone. In France, the [Dreyfus affair](#) erupted when a French Jewish officer was wrongfully accused of spying for the Germans. And German politicians won on anti-Semitic platforms.

But as the economy improved, this wave of anti-Semitism died down. But the mold seems to have been set in classrooms. In particular, Völkisch, Darwinist and colonialist thought were very, very popular. Anti-Semitism was a useful outlet for those who felt something had gone wrong, but couldn't quite put their finger on what. Many of Hitler's influences and early circle — like [Dietrich Eckart](#) — were artists, poets, playwrights who could blame Jewish academies and Jewish control of the arts when their own work went underappreciated.

Later in Mein Kampf, bringing these themes of the Völkisch, the Darwinist struggle, and the medicalized analogy and metaphors together, plus the anti-Semitism of course, Hitler wrote that the [Jews were a pestilence worse than the Black Death](#), a maggot in the decomposing body of Germany.

Chapter Five: Syndicalism, Socialists, and their Discontents

Italy wanted — they needed — an empire like the rest of the great powers. In the second half of the [19th century, Italian merchants and forces began occupying what is now Eritrea in eastern Africa](#). Then in 1887, at [Dogali](#), the Italians with advanced Western industrialized weapons, expected swift victories against supposedly backwards Ethiopia, but in what became known in Italy as the [tragedy of Dogali](#), the detachment of 500 Italians were ambushed by 10,000 Ethiopian warriors, depicted in this wonderfully orientalist painting, and they were then trapped in the hills in the sweltering heat, and the Italians were slaughtered one by one. It was a national humiliation. There was an outcry back in Italy, and there were even riots across the country.

Germany and Italy were very different countries. Italy was seen as the weakest of the so-called great powers. It was largely agricultural, divided with little overall national consciousness. Germany across the 19th century developed into one of the top three most industrially and scientifically advanced nations on the planet. [Italy had low literacy rates and Germany very high](#), but both countries were united into single nations around the same time — 1871 in Germany and across the 1860s in Italy. Both were conscious of having some kind of great history to look back nostalgically on. Both had this mix of greatness and insecurity.

Capitalism across the 19th century was destabilizing. It had great promise. Technology, machines, materials, weapons. But it was seen to be, by many in different ways, running away from the Volk, the stable, the rooted. The Enlightenment had unleashed a plurality of competing ideas — liberal, socialist, anarchist, and all the variants of each and everything else in between. And both Germany and Italy were divided about what to do.

By the beginning of the 20th century, the [German Socialist Party](#) was the largest political party in the world. It was Marxist, but it was reformist too. It rejected cooperating with bourgeois parties, and, as Evans puts it: "the social democratic movement struck terror into the hearts of the respectable middle and upper classes." The liberals were making big gains across Europe — parliaments, rights and free speech, larger franchises, some reforms — and so many socialists moved towards reform rather than revolution. Reform was seen in many ways across many decades, as working, as at least doing some good work.

A small group of radicals in France became tired of this. They believed in Marxist proper revolution. They rejected reform entirely, and in fact, many of them hated anything to do with the state, with parliaments, with governments. They thought it was a load of idle chatter. Best an ideological capture, at worst. And there was a lot of crossover between different groups like anarchists and socialists and the subgroups, and a lot of disagreement.

But a new group, syndicalists, believed that the state itself was the problem — that power should be in the hands of those that produce, that actually do things, that do the work. These [syndicalists sometimes called themselves Marxists](#), but they were very unorthodox Marxists. What's surprising here, and what we need to explore, is this. In his history of fascism, the historian [Stanley Payne](#) writes that the nucleus that eventually founded fascism in Italy did not, however, stem either from the cultural elite or from the right-wing nationalists, but from

the transformation of parts of the revolutionary left, particularly the sector known as the [revolutionary syndicalists](#).

Much of our story revolves around that big question of what is to be done — the Jewish question, the socialist one, the capitalist one, the spiritual or cultural one, the scientific one. How do we get on? Keep up, move forward. What's right? A moral question that's often forgotten when it comes to a system like fascism that seems so antithetical to us, at least to morality at all. But that was still the big question — what's the right? What's the good thing to do? What's the moral thing to do when we have talking-shop parliaments in Rome, disconnected from the peasantry, talking about effete abstract ideas, and getting our brothers, sons, our soldiers killed by savages in Africa? This can't be right.

The [theorist Georges Sorel](#) is key to this story. He was a French syndicalist. He hated intellectuals. He hated the talking shops in the parliaments and the liberals. And he hated the history of intellectuals, too. He hated Socrates yapping and stuttering, talking dialectically with his fellow Athenians in abstractions and high-minded, highfalutin ideas. What is the good life and how do you lead it? Who shall rule the state? The philosopher king, the aristocrat, and the people? He liked instead — and there's a bit of Nietzsche in Sorel — heroes, villains, action, bravery. If we listen to intellectuals, he said, quote, there will be no longer any soldiers or sailors, but only skeptical and witty shopkeepers.

Sorel was fascinated by how heroic myths have been central in the history of great civilizations. Myths like [Homer's Odyssey](#) and the [Iliad](#), myths about great gods from Zeus to Brahma to Thor, or knights and chivalry. These were stories that had survived through centuries and millennia. These were stories that appealed to people and inspired people, and led to real, genuine action and movement. And he believed that the point of a myth wasn't about whether it was true or false, but that they were models for emulation, guidance. They were moral stories that led to results in the real world. In the concrete world, myths were on a different plane than empirical, realist reality. Myths as well could be about the past to emulate, stories about heroes. Or they could be stories about the future, about what to expect, about what to do.

Sorel wrote that myths incite action, to quote him: "when we act, that means we have created an entirely artificial world, placed in front of the present and formed out of movements that depend on us. In this way, our liberty becomes entirely intelligible."

The big what-should-we-do question Sorel asked was: why are revolutions not happening despite such widespread working class movements? Why were Marx's insights about the inevitable collapse of capitalism not coming to pass? Socialists were becoming, he thought, reformists, collaborating with the enemy. What's more, Marx believed that the workers had no country. They were united by being proletariat. That's what they had in common. Yet national solidarity was clearly more powerful than international proletariat, universalist solidarity.

Sorel concluded that the proletariat had failed to fulfill the role that Marx had set for them, that Marx had not foreseen that liberals and the bourgeoisie could essentially buy off the

proletariat by giving them small morsels of reform, and they could do this and stop them revolting. Stop the revolution. What Sorel thought the proletariat needed to release them from that only slightly improved chains of industrial bondage was a great motivating myth, a great model for action.

He thought that Marx, as a materialist, had underappreciated the effect of ideas, of psychology, of symbols, of stories, of words. He asked: what was the central organizing myth that could kick the proletariat into shape? What was the mythical event that would change the world? It was the myth of the great heroic general strike, the big struggle, the one that brings all of society to a complete standstill, the one that prepares the ground for revolution.

Finally, the proletariat needed the myth makers, the storytellers, the leaders, the motivators — an elite, a vanguard. But Sorel differed from Marx in a crucial way. He rejected the idea of a proletarian dictatorship and the centralizing role of the state, because he hated all of that talking-shop stuff. He envisioned a society where producers, people who do and make, organize through unions, controlled the means of production, the factories, the industry directly through autonomous workers' syndicates operating within a market economy, led by efficient worker-producer elites.

His most well-known work, [Reflections on Violence](#), published in 1908, was immediately popular amongst French radicals and quickly spread across the border into Italy. Sorel was, like most intellectuals, plugged in to that Darwinian culture of the day — the culture of struggle, a culture that had a shared heritage in philosophers like Marx and Hegel. He wrote that class struggle is the alpha and omega of socialism, but the emphasis on struggle was why he thought a type of capitalism was inevitable, just a new type, because it was a struggle between people and ideas and material production — that some kind of competition between competing syndicates was a great agent, an engine of change, of progress.

Many in Europe on the left and the right were worried about decadence, moral decay, laziness, drunkenness, greed, the kind of stagnant bourgeoisie that were too comfortable, a lack of direction. Antidotes to this, of course, differed across the political spectrum, but this critique was quite widespread. And for Sorel, heroism and myth were the answer — bravery, sacrifice, glory, survival, brotherhood. The heroic side of the class struggle against a villainous enemy, the stagnant, greedy bourgeoisie.

So, for Sorel, the general strike was the key to all of this. One history I was reading — I can't remember which one — claimed that in 1906 there were half a million strikes. But I know that seems implausible. But these were the years that were the height of unrest. Strikers would share small portions of saved-up food with each other, would catch cramp fishing at low tide, would be fishing and foraging, and soldiers would shoot strikers to get back to work.

This was a great heroic struggle. In Russia in 1905, hundreds were killed in [Bloody Sunday](#). Sorel believed you needed selfless heroes of the strike. Myth makers, brotherhood, solidarity. And then, of course, the villains. [Édouard Berth](#), a syndicalist and a student of Sorel and a follower of the philosopher Henri Bergson, who again was very, very popular at the time, maybe the most popular philosopher in Europe — Berth wrote: The strike is a

phenomenon of collective life and psychology. Here very powerful, very contagious, almost electric sentiments come into play. The will of each worker is submerged and absorbed in this unity. Individual egoism, private interests, miserable personal preoccupations, and little secret weaknesses disappear. There is now only an electrified mass, a complex collective personality transported all together with a single, unanimous and powerful upsurge to the highest peaks of heroism and the sentiment of the sublime.

And Sorel believed in this. He believed that during a strike, violence, ethical violence could appear as something very beautiful, very heroic. For not only can proletarian violence ensure the future revolution, but it seems to be the only means by which the European nations, deadened by humanism, can regain their former energy.

Sorel moved further and further away from [orthodox Marxism](#). He hated democracy more than anything, and you have to bear in mind that democracy is a very nebulous concept. You can have kind of, you know, [bourgeois liberal market democracy](#), or you can have socialist true democracy where workers run everything, and everything is kind of voted on from the bottom up in an anarchist way. And then you can have a kind of communist democracy where you believe democracy has to be protected by other means. So democracy means many things to many different people. But Sorel was talking about [parliamentary democracy](#). He absolutely hated it. And he hated the kind of rule by the bottom up, the rule by the mob.

So he moved towards nationalism as a carrier of national myths, an organizer of everyday people, a motivator for action. And again, how true has this been, how convincing this is, if you really think about it. Because even today, nothing has proven more powerful, more of an enduring ideology. It's national identity.

Berth and another influential syndicalist, [Georges Valois](#), started a French group inspired by Sorel's ideas called the [Cercle Proudhon](#). They took syndicalism in an even more nationalist direction. Before, the founder Valois wrote: Today it is nationalism that carries the forces of reason and sentiment that will henceforth be responsible for social transformations. This ascension of nationalism, he said — the result that one sees national values replacing socialist values in the public mind — the national syndicalist Cercle Proudhon declared: democracy is the greatest error of the past century. If one wishes to live, if one wishes to work, if one wishes in social life to possess the greatest human guarantees for production and culture. If one wishes to preserve and increase the moral, intellectual and material capital of civilization, it is absolutely necessary to destroy all democratic institutions.

In his incredibly detailed book on the history of this, [The Birth of Fascist Ideology](#), historian [Zeev Sternhell](#) says that this was the key turning point, the point when a radically new type of elite, different from the economic or liberal elites, or even the conservative elites of democracies and monarchies, came about and sought to mobilize the masses by means of myths. And this was also supported by an idea of action, an idea of violence. It was anti-Enlightenment, anti-rational. It was revolutionary and so contained many of the later ingredients for fascism, even if they had to be distorted and mixed in with other things as we'll get to. But not all of these syndicalists of course were fascistic, and not all fascists were

first syndicalists. There were still socialists in the class, but they believed in getting rid of the state entirely and putting industry in the hands of the unions, of the syndicates.

Sternhell writes:

"The solution was thus intended as a complete replacement of the liberal order. They wished to create a new world — virile, heroic, pessimistic and puritanical, based on the sense of duty and sacrifice, a world where a morality of warriors and monks would prevail. They wanted a society dominated by a powerful avant-garde, a proletarian elite and aristocracy of producers, joined in alliance against the decadent bourgeoisie with an intellectual youth, avid for action."

This is something we're not used to today — that you can be on the left and anti-democratic, that unions can be revolutionary but still retain their hierarchies and have elitism. That nationalists and leftists could, of course, be the same thing. Remember, nationalists were often fighting for national freedoms, to emancipate themselves from oppressive empires across Europe and the world. Nationalism in this period had very, very different connotations than it does today. You have to remember this. You could be progressive, anti-democracy, nationalistic and socialist all at the same time. Most people in every state.

Sorel's thought was influential on Italy's trajectory, but not in Germany. And Völkisch thought in Germany, but not in Italy. But if you broaden them out — that there had to be a different way to manage unwieldy capitalism, that the nation, the group, the great power or the Volk had to come first. That struggle was key and enemies inevitable. That myth, national story, symbols, culture was central. You get an idea of a general emerging counter-spirit of the age, counter to the rationalist, materialist and liberal models of the Enlightenment. And what could be more counter to the idea of Enlightenment than violence?

Chapter Six: The Cult of the Violent

Mussolini was a clown. At least that's how history has often remembered him. But this is a mistake. [Mussolini read philosophy widely, spoke four languages, left 44 volumes of writings. He loved poetry, music, Russian literature. He was an intellectual.](#) He was a teacher, but he was also ruthless and violent. [He stabbed a classmate in the hand when he was ten.](#) He was expelled for being uncontrollable. He is, I think, the most fascinating paradox.

The young Mussolini, in a lot of ways, embodied everything we've looked at so far. He was a committed socialist. He read very widely. He knew Darwin and Sorel. He believed in Italian nationhood and building up the cultural and social idea of Italy. And he believed in greatness. And Italy, long oppressed by the Austrians, who controlled much of the North of the country. Even in his early years of dictatorship, later on, so many foreign leaders admired him — British aristocrats, American public opinion, and [Roosevelt](#), who called him admirable. Even [Gandhi](#) noted his initial admiration.

We think of fascism as hard and violent, tough, ordered. But there's something that comes up again and again about the period that we so easily forget today. It was hard and violent. It was a tough period. Even socialism, which we so often see today as something about welfare and things like this — it was about, in the period, violent struggle, tough industrialists, tough workers, war, authority, repressiveness. That was the status quo accepted as a fact of life for so many. And so many saw war and progress as intimately connected, as one and the same — that you didn't get progress and good things without tough, hard, violent struggle.

Take the [Risorgimento](#) — Italian unification in 1861. It was only possible through war, by violently expelling Austria from controlling parts of the north of Italy. Similarly, German unification through Prussian domination expelled Austrian imperial interference at around the same time. Hence [Bismarck's famous phrase that the great issues of the day would be settled through blood and iron](#).

The idea that violence and war are inevitable seems quickly justified by history, and in scientific Darwinian struggle, and you might quickly turn violence from something to be avoided, something to be scared of, to something to be inevitably embraced. One syndicalist, [Arturo Labriola](#), justified violence by saying this: in the hands of a surgeon, a sharp blade confers health; in the hands of an assassin, it destroys life. In other words, a wound, if purposefully directed, can be a good thing.

And so the Futurists, led by [Filippo Tommaso Marinetti](#), they were a movement which emphasized modernity, technology, speed, violence, action. If you haven't read the short [1909 Futurist Manifesto](#), it's a must. I'll pick some key words from it here. It talks of the love of danger, energy, fearlessness, courage. It's smart, aggressive action, strides and leaps. It talks about speed. It uses language like explosive, breath roaring. It says: "we hold the wheel of his spirit across the earth. Primordial elements. It talks about struggle. The number nine says we will glorify war. The world's only hygiene, militarism, patriotism, the destructive gesture of freedom-bringers, beautiful ideas worth dying for."

The Futurists were fierce northern Italian industrialists. Think about Italy, divided between a so-called backwards agricultural south and these excited, energetic, industrial, technical poet youths in the North. [In 1913, Marinetti wrote](#):

"the future needs blood, it needs human victims, butchery, internal war and far more — revolution and conquest. That is history. Blood is the wine of strong peoples and blood is the oil for the wheels of this great machine which flies from the past to the future."

I mean, take the British Empire. It was both technologically advanced — ships and artillery and all the rest — and it had some kind of Lebensraum beyond its meager size. It had Canada and Australia and India and Africa. It had it all through industry and blunt force, and it instilled jealousy in all nationalists around the world.

And finally, there's a general idea of Nietzsche floating around — not the man himself, but the idea of him, compatible with the idea of struggle, with Darwinism. A figure who also

criticized the pen-pushers of the Enlightenment, who criticized Socrates, a man known above all for the idea that morals, new values, new men could be created through a will to power. Nietzsche and his ideas have been blamed and fought over and questioned and exonerated, and his works are rich and complex and have been twisted by so many, even his sister leading up to the Nazis. But in a very vague, general sense, his idea of herd morality left behind by an [Übermensch](#) forging his own moral path forward could, at the very least, be simplistically adopted by those who had views that Nietzsche himself would have, and did in sections of his work, repudiate. He was, for example, an opponent of anti-Semitism and of kind of naive, vulgar German nationalism.

So all of this was in the air when the most violent event in human history breaks out — the First World War. For Italy, the war aims were squared at Austrian control of the land to the north, perceived to be Italian, the so-called *terre irredente* — the unredeemed lands. We have to remember the struggle over borders of empires and nations wasn't just some abstract idea, some lines drawn on maps. Some towns, many villages were half Italian, half Slavic, part French or Germanic. Many nations in Europe, we have to remember, were and even are still today so much more porous, sometimes ambiguous. And so the politics of struggle in these places, national struggle, could be very material, very real.

But while many welcomed the violence of the war, in Italy for the most part still there was little enthusiasm. Peasants didn't understand the point. They were often not interested in new ideas like national identity, nationalism. They didn't really understand themselves as ethnically or culturally Italian, of course, didn't read about Italian history or the struggles to unify it. Deserters were largely executed during the war. Mutinies were very common in Italy. There was no unity, no national unity. [There were around a million military trials.](#)

For example, one historian describes a famously brutal general at the time like this: he had 19 men shot in the back for sundry offenses on the morning of the 16th of November alone. Another man, [Alessandro Ruffini](#), was shot for saluting without taking his pipe out of his mouth. And the war in the Alps was particularly gruesome. A white war where more died from cold than bullets, where advances were slow or non-existent, where one advance of 25 miles cost 200,000 Italian lives.

Not only was there little enthusiasm, but the socialists, remember, were internationalists. Proletarians of the world! Unite! They weren't just apathetic to the war effort, but violently anti-war. Ironically, and in a way, this made the pro-war, violent struggle advocates even more pro-violence. They doubled down. They argued that the peasantry needed radicalizing to believe in the importance of a war for their nation, for themselves, for who they were. They just didn't know it yet. Apparently.

The war created, in [John Foot](#)'s words: "a violent generation, a sacrificial generation" — to, as Jünger said right at the beginning, the generation who struggled and found some kind of heightened, glorifying, spiritualizing meaning in amongst all of this horror, all of this bloodshed, all of this mud and dirt and trauma. John Foot's book on Italian fascism, [Blood and Power](#), actually reads like an encyclopedia of violence that arose in many ways from

that great war, a war that got worse and worse and worse — poison gas, aerial bombing, submarine warfare, flamethrowers, endless amputations, let alone gruesome deaths.

[Robert Payne](#) writes: "The virtually static trench fronts tied down millions for months on end, creating a new collective consciousness of a separate society — a warrior group partially isolated from the rest of the nation and from normal experiences." Take the infamous [Italian Arditi](#), meaning the daring ones. The Arditi were elite shock troops during the war, some of the most feared of any country. They were trained in close hand-to-hand combat, in using daggers and explosives. These were the ultimate men of violence, and they brought this camaraderie home with them. They resented shirkers and deserters and socialists and internationalists and pacifists, and they in turn hated them back.

A guy called [Ferruccio Vecchi](#) — he was one of them. And he wrote after the war this: We would like to thank the Army and apologize for the fact that we did not all die. This was our hope and our duty. He was a key figure in the early squadristi groups of fascists that banded together to fight socialists in the countryside of Italy. And we'll get to more of them in a sec.

But in other words, what I'm saying is fascism emerged up out of these groups. Remember these words: Arditi and squadristi, sometimes squadristo. The movement from Band of Brothers War to bands of brothers at home. That movement is crucial here, and that's what we're going to get to in a sec.

The German experience was just as shaped by the violence of the war. There were groups fighting in trenches in France that were suddenly told they'd lost — time to go home — but they felt like they'd been winning. How was that possible? No one had invaded Germany. And not only that, after the loss of the First World War, the German fleet, submarines, tanks, guns, military equipment — that all had to be given up, given over to the enemy when they felt like they hadn't been defeated on the battlefield.

[Germany's territory shrank by 13% plus 10% of the population as the borders changed](#). The allies took ships, trains, over 100,000 coaches, loads of coal. Plus the Germans had to pay reparations and accept, quote unquote, sole guilt for the war. But people will often point to this as being highly unfair and a major cause for what comes later on. I think the terms were much too harsh, and it's difficult not to agree with that. But we have to remember that German terms, if Germany had won, were planned to be even harsher.

Evans writes that the reparations bills that Germany actually did have to pay from 1919 onwards were not beyond the country's resources to meet and not unreasonable, given the wanton destruction visited upon Belgium and France by the occupying German armies.

So the forces coming home believed they'd been stabbed in the back by weak, capitulating internal traitors back home in these talking-shop parliaments, or sometimes Jews and Communists — not patriots and good nationalists, good people that love their country and their families. Germany quickly descended into chaos, into mutinies and revolutions and street battles and occupations. It was a country in almost everything but civil war. Allied troops occupied a strip of the Rhineland for most of the 1920s. Resentment filled veterans

returned from the front to find liberal and socialist revolutionaries on the streets, attacking them. After everything they'd done. After serving for their country.

Street fights broke out immediately and escalated, and those veterans had learned order and brotherhood and belonging in tight-knit, nationalist, hierarchical units. So they organized. They took army courses, nationalist courses. They read, and they sometimes often adopted anti-Semitic, Völkisch or anti-rationalist ideas. [One veteran remembered in his diary:](#)

"Though limping along with the aid of my cane at the Potsdam station in Berlin, a band of uniformed men sporting red armbands stopped me and demanded that I surrender my epaulets and insignia — his badges. I raised my stick in reply, but my rebellion was soon overcome. I was thrown down and only the intervention of a railroad official saved me from my humiliating position. Hate flamed in me against the November criminals. From that moment after one of his friends was assaulted, another remembered that the red rabble, which had never heard a bullet whistle, had assaulted him and torn off all his insignia and medals. We screamed with rage for this kind of Germany. We had sacrificed our blood and our health and breathed all of the torments of hell and a world of enemies. For years."

[Inflation hit Italy and Germany hard almost immediately.](#) Groups like the Steel Helmets formed to provide financial support for struggling veterans. [The Steel Helmets quickly rose to 300,000 members, then to a million.](#) They organized marches and demonstrations. One in Berlin had 132,000 Steel Helmet members marching in uniform. They called out: the Steel Helmet fights for the German Volk and therefore for the renewal of the Germanic race. It fights to strengthen German self-consciousness so that foreign racial influences will be eliminated from the nation.

[The Fatherland Party](#) was another [Pan-Germanic](#) popular group with over a million members, and these groups mostly had a natural affinity with Völkisch ideas and lots of smaller Völkisch groups. The conservative parties realized much too late that they might be able to get the great masses, the mob, on their side — for the working classes weren't just destined to support liberals, socialists or communists, or just be non-thinking, non-political nonentities.

Some conservative politicians in the mainstream became more focused on anti-Semitism, knowing it would win votes. [Reinhold Wulle](#) was known as "Wulle with a stick" because he attacked Jews so much. A coalition was emerging slowly and loosely around veterans, Völkisch groups and some conservative politicians. These veteran groups were aligned with the many youth groups, the teachers, the boarding schools that had sprung up and were mostly organized on kind of Völkisch ideas. The youth Bünde — places where the special rooted character of Germans united with a feeling of eros, of love between a tightly bonded group of men.

[The Thule Bund](#), organized in 1918, was formed to fight supposed secret Jewish organizations and plans, plans that had contributed to overthrowing the old order. Many

countries had something similar, but studies of German textbooks have shown Völkisch principles to be particularly strong amongst middle-class German teachers teaching the next generation of German kids, which were also surrounded by this chaotic failure of liberal parliamentary democracy. In that kind of setting and upbringing, what are you going to see as good and evil?

Mosse writes:

"Modernity was universally and irrevocably condemned. The spirit of the Germanic forebears, the primitive but heroic inhabitants of the Teutonic forests were held up as examples to be emulated."

Another source of support came from boarding schools, which were quite new at the time and were inspired by English boarding schools. There's one near me where a German educator called [Hermann Lietz](#) came to teach in the 19th century. He so admired the English system that he took home the motto: education spells Empire. Lietz's successor [Alfred Andreesen](#) became a National Socialist, and he went on to praise the schools of Hitler as the culmination of Lietz's work. And I think it's really interesting to reflect on this lineage between the British Empire, the British private boarding education system and educators in Germany, through to Hitler — that idea that education spells Empire. If it's done in the right way, if it's done with national consciousness and order and hierarchy at heart.

The English system concentrated on [Anglicanism](#) — essentially a kind of, and this isn't right, but it's a good tool for thinking, a kind of Völkisch Christianity — English history and greatness and physical prowess. Lietz went back to Germany and founded the first German version of these English boarding schools in 1898, and boarding schools are the perfect place to mold kids with a very specific nationalistic ideology with hierarchy. In this case, Germany needed to reject the kind of foreign aspects of the Enlightenment and build up something special through their children, through their youth.

Mosse writes:

"To a large extent, all of these factors coalesced to create the new martial and heroic feeling of the soldiers returning home. The war and the events resulting from it had infused both the Bünde and the youth movement with a renewed spirit of national consciousness."

These paramilitary organizations became so large and powerful, political parties began associating with them, courting their support, aligning themselves with them. There's a kind of meeting in the middle. Some groups had ultra-violent offshoots that practiced revenge killings against communists, and these parts were either ostracized or ignored, or in some cases, strategically used.

So the working classes were poor and more likely to support communism or socialism. The middle and upper classes were seeing what had just happened in Russia and became increasingly scared of revolution. Germany seemed on the brink of becoming Soviet.

A 1919 uprising in Berlin was quashed, and its communist leaders, [Karl Liebknecht](#) and [Rosa Luxemburg](#), were murdered. At least a thousand were killed in a regional civil war, and another [uprising in Hamburg in 1923](#) was similarly violently repressed. And another paramilitary group, the Freikorps, had over half a million members. They would assassinate opposition leaders, would fight against communists, would engage in violence on the streets, and march in uniform.

To put it simply, the militarization of war had returned to domestic streets. These men were institutionalized, and there were so many of these groups — groups of belonging, groups of brotherhood — to join for radicalized, traumatized, and bored veterans. One, for example, was simply called the [Association Against the Arrogance of the Jews](#). The communists of the [Red Front Fighters' League](#), [the Freikorps](#), [the Steel Helmets](#), and others would fight for the control of neighborhoods. One historian has called it [quasi-guerrilla warfare](#). One young Nazi called them the red murder mob. The screaming, screeching hordes, hate-filled, furious faces worthy of study by a criminologist.

Evans writes:

"It was in this atmosphere of national trauma, political extremism, violent conflict and revolutionary upheaval that Nazism was born. Some have called the Freikorps the vanguard of Nazism."

You cannot overemphasize the importance of the war. Either you were in it or you knew many that were — friends, family, neighbors, dead or wounded. Struggling borders changed. Debt. Inflation, yes, but also the militarization of huge parts of society, authority, hierarchy, propaganda, industry and home life all geared towards war aims. Total war. For the first time in history, there's story after story of brutal violence, of destruction, of an awfulness of the human condition.

But for the moment, the fragile middle held. Fascism rose from the paramilitary violence on the streets. Evans says: Without the war, Nazism would not have emerged as a serious political force.

Chapter Seven: When Things Fall Apart

What does it mean to be modern? We've seen the rejection of the Enlightenment, of abstract ideas by thinkers sat in disconnected universities or libraries talking about made-up things like rights. This stuff was everywhere. Feminism, abstract art, communism, parliaments talking about the right to speak, to associate, to print. All of this supposedly above, better than traditional heroism, feeling, rootedness, order and hierarchy.

What else does it mean? Materialism, factories, consumerism, the collecting of pointless material stuff over the cultivation of traditional spiritual values, or of this abstract art, the radio, the jazz clubs, the dancing in cities with the homeless and the rudeness, the Jewish.

And what about Bolsheviks? These universalists, Jewish, Enlightenment nonsense, madness, Red terror.

Many across Europe were scared and disorientated. The Russian Revolution had been brutal. White terror against Bolsheviks turned into Red terror in retaliation. Hundreds of thousands died. [Béla Kun](#) led a short-lived Hungarian Soviet Republic in 1919 — initial [Red terror that turned into White Terror](#) when Kun's communist regime was overthrown by monarchists.

In Germany, a [Bavarian Soviet Republic was declared in 1918](#), lasting around a year. So in 1918 to 1919, Europe looked very much like it could turn red entirely.

In Germany, the Kaiser fled, and the parliamentary [SPD, the Social Democrats](#), proclaimed a liberal Weimar Republic, a constitutional liberal republic with a powerful president, as was the tradition in Germany. It was, they, from the beginning, despised absolutely by both communists on the left and monarchists and nationalists on the right. [Weimar liberals were widely blamed for losing the war. Millions of children grew up without fathers, in broken families, broken homes.](#) Many who did come home couldn't even work because they had an injury, maybe a missing arm or a leg or two. Pensions and welfare were being paid to almost a million veterans.

Germany borrowed a lot of money during the war, with no guaranteed means of repaying it. In Bavaria, the communists under the playwright [Ernst Toller](#), then Lenin ally [Eugen Leviné](#), trained an army of [20,000 men to defend the Bavarian Soviet, but then counter-revolutionary Freikorps soldiers were stronger and better trained, coming out of the army, being led by military men. 35,000 of them headed to Munich in an armored train.](#) They quickly quashed the communists in a bloodbath. Communists were beaten, tortured and executed. The defense of "shot while trying to escape" is a phrase that comes up a lot in [early fascist violence. 500 to 1000 were killed.](#)

Evans writes:

"Munich became a playground for extremist political sects, as virtually every social and political group in the city burned with resentment, fear and lust for revenge. Public order more or less vanished."

Another nationalist coup was attempted in 1920, the so-called [Kapp Putsch](#). Mosse points out that, quote, much of the postwar fascist movement was built upon the ideals of youth and activism, that there was a youthful energy to it, an overflowing of passion and will. And it's of note that that 1920 Kapp Putsch was supported by 50,000 students and youth group members. The putschists were nationalists. They hated the Weimar Republic. They hated the postwar treaty that Germany was forced to sign. But even though it revealed the weaknesses of the young Weimar Republic, it failed. Still, it was a sign of the constant chaos across most of Europe.

The [Bolsheviks had called for an international general strike in 1918](#), and over in Italy the chaos was similar. Liberals were blamed for poor war gains that amounted to almost nothing. Even though they were on the winning side, the experience of war had been awful and pointless. Debt and inflation were skyrocketing out of control. Socialists were winning elections and unions controlled large parts of the country.

Italian communist maximalists urged joining the Bolshevik revolution — that it wasn't Russian or Italian. It was workers of the world, uniting. There was a [Red Week in 1914](#), a widespread rebellion that almost turned into a revolution. Then the [Biennio Rosso — the Two Red Years — 1919 to 1920](#). These were characterized by thousands of strikes, street battles, unionization. Thousands of union workers took direct control of factories, flying socialist flags. Revolution looked very near and kind of inevitable.

In his [history of Italian Fascism, Blood and Power](#), historian John Foot writes that during Red Week, churches were burned, stations invaded by the mob, barricades were built in the streets, and freedom trees — nuts, trees or poles carrying flags and radical slogans, following a tradition going all the way back to the French Revolution — were raised in the center of squares. It was pretty much a proto-civil war. The government lost control of areas of Romagna and Ancona.

One journalist wrote, quote, the population is gripped by panic. There's widespread fear that things will get worse. Many people have barricaded themselves in their homes. Every book I've looked at has story after story of strike, protest, brutal. The ransacking of newspaper offices, especially socialist ones, of course, but also some liberal ones, some assassinations and endless ongoing strikes and street fights.

[Historian Marco Severini wrote of the Red Week](#) that a good part of central Italy was paralyzed and isolated for a number of days, increasing a sense of utopia, but also fears, exaggerating the role of agitators and militants who would soon be forgotten, and leaving a tragic trail of bloodshed which would prove to be a preview of the destruction of the World War.

And back in Germany, [hyperinflation was spinning out of control](#). The government were quickly falling behind on the reparation repayments that they had to pay because of the Versailles Treaty. They couldn't pay France, and so French troops occupied the Ruhr in 1923. This was an industrial area, highly productive, part of the wealth of Germany, and was deeply embarrassing for Germans living there.

Hyperinflation got so bad that money lost all meaning. Many prices couldn't keep up and only one side of the note was printed. At one point, wages were collected in baskets and wheelbarrows. Food prices went up while you were eating in a café.

In 1923, the Daily Mail — more respected then, let's say — reported: in the shops, the prices are typewritten and posted hourly. For instance, a gramophone at 10 a.m. was 5 million marks, but at 3 p.m. it was 12 million marks. A copy of the Daily Mail purchased on the street yesterday cost 35,000 marks, but today it cost 60,000 marks.

Welfare payments added to financial pressure. Big business often despised being forced to pay for welfare. Remember, this was something very new to them in history. Veterans and the unemployed needed supporting. Bankruptcies led to companies buying up competitors and large cartels forming as the big companies swallowed up the smaller ones. Gangs of hundreds roamed the countryside stealing crops. Food riots broke out. Convictions skyrocketed. Prisons were bursting at the seams. [One prisoner reported that 68 of 100 men that were sent to them had no shoes](#), and 50 of them had no shirt. The entire country was quite literally collapsing, starving, failing to function.

Germans became culturally obsessed — and I think this is important for the mentality of fascism — with crime stories, debauchery, cheating, and of course, the greedy Jew. [The Center Party](#) spent much of their time fighting things like pornography and contraception. That the whole country, spiritually and materially, was going to hell in a handbasket.

The artist [George Grosz](#) — I ought to show you some of these, but go and look at more — captured the chaos of Germany in the 20s. He painted and drew criminality and deviancy and sex and chaos in a new Dada style that captured that unrooted, abstract, undefinable modernity that anti-Enlightenment thinkers came to despise.

And the average person — remember, and remember, I'm sorry to say this over and over again, remember to put yourself in this position — does not live in a city, does not listen to new jazz. The average person is very, very religious and traditional and Völkisch, does not think about the philosophy of rationality, of logic, of reason. All they know is that life is very hard, stories are probably still mostly oral, that violence and criminality is everywhere. You're doing the same thing — plowing your field, building furniture, whatever it is. But no matter what you do, you're on the verge of bankruptcy. You can't find work. Maybe starvation. And all of this, plus the stab in the back, was associated with the weak, effete talking-shop, the rambling of Weimar parliamentarians, its rich people in cities that are unable to do anything. They're not effective in the slightest.

Evans says:

"Weimar was weak in political legitimacy from the start. Weimar Republic went through over 20 governments in the 14 years between the end of the First World War in 1919 and the end of democracy in 1933. Many were unstable coalitions. Most ordinary people were either conservative and hated Weimar or were communist and hated it too. The army, the police, the judiciary, the courts, and the judges tended to prosecute those on the left more and turn a blind eye to those on the right. Even the civil service, often conservative through to the core, actively tried to thwart Parliament and its liberal new ways."

We think of parliaments and democracy as normal, of course, but this was not. It was brand new. It was abnormal and it was failing. What good are debates and arguments again? What good is the talking shop when you need a doer, you need a man of action?

Many people have memories — and they may be nostalgic memories nonetheless — of a more stable past. If you were, say, a teenager, your grandparents remembered Bismarck, remembered more settled, predictable, agrarian lives. Surely when looking at the chaos all around us, we should just go back.

And because this isn't an ordinary, you know, historical narrative of fascism, forgive me for playing with time a little bit here, because I'm thinking of it conceptually as ingredients, of building up layers of a fascist. And so fast forward ten years in Germany, right? And the Great Depression hits, too, with the memory of hyperinflation and the hatred of Weimar fresh in the mind of most Germans.

People were out of work for years. Millions were homeless. Evans puts it like this:

"informal hiking clubs and working-class youth groups easily became so-called wild cliques, gangs of young people who met in disused buildings, scavenged food, stole to make a living, fought with rival gangs and frequently clashed with the police."

[In 1932, 1 in 3 Germans were unemployed](#). That's 13 million people, including their families and dependents. The great and sad irony of the welfare state is that the more an economy fails, the more people need help, and the less the state has the money to help. Because the tax receipts have reduced. Communists had made huge gains in membership, but many of its members were jobless, and there were hunger marches across the country. Evans talks about the communists being rich in members but poor in resources. They had communist pubs, communist hangouts, but they had to be closed. They couldn't pay the rent. Street battles for territory continued.

Ask yourself this — and remember, you're an ordinary person that reads the news maybe once a week on a Sunday. If you don't like the chaos of liberalism and are fearful of capitalism, unrestrained new capitalism. But you don't like communism, and you see what's happening in Russia and you don't want to be controlled by Russia. What are the alternatives? Hereditary monarchy? That seems for the world of yesterday. How can some kind of well-working order come out of all this chaos?

And one answer to this was corporatism. There is a kind of loose convergence here between Völkisch and syndicalist thought, Völkisch in Germany and syndicalist in France and Italy. Both liked [corporatism](#). And you have to bear in mind corporatism doesn't mean what it does today or how we often think of it. It basically means society organized into neatly defined interest groups, corporations with different roles, and it's a reaction or a response or remedy to individualism, to capitalism, to bourgeois liberal society.

Political scientist [Philippe Schmitter](#) puts it like this:

"it's a system of interest representation in which the constituent units, social and economic sectors, are organized into a limited number of singular, compulsory, non-competitive, hierarchically ordered and functionally differentiated categories, recognized

or licensed if not created by the state, and granted a deliberate representational monopoly within their respective categories in exchange for observing certain controls."

So you'd have a steel corporation and a timber corporation and a trade union corporation and a public utilities corporation and a roads corporation. The idea was that they were fixed and stable, as a response to chaos, and that they could be in part both managed by entrepreneurs, or privately, in combination with politicians and the public interest. I think it's in a sense a utopian ideal of society. And it was backward-looking. It was palingenetic in that it looked back to the kind of romanticized stability of the Middle Ages.

So, Sorel, for example, believed in a syndicalism that would get rid of the state entirely and replace it with well-defined corporations run by the unions. Völkisch groups often believed in a third way between socialism and capitalism, where each rooted group had its place in the German order, and they were often expressed in utopian novels or in some cases real communities, especially in America or in some parts of Germany.

[Moeller van den Bruck](#) believed in a German socialism that was a synthesis of medieval corporatism and German Völkisch thought. He rejected Marxism because, he said, every people has its own socialism. This was popular in different ways across Germany.

One colony was called Eden and it was founded on corporatist Völkisch principles back in 1893. Even mainstream German economics at the time was very unique. German economists were often opposed to laissez-faire individualism. Economists like Adolph Wagner advocated for a Volkswirtschaft, a people's economy, which involved rationalizing industry with state intervention, again to prevent chaos. And German states often nationalized trains and utilities and mining and some industry.

Ironically, it's very Enlightenment-esque, and there's a tension between these kinds of trends — one, that you could rationally order corporations and the nation into a stable, logical set of organizations through rational and logical principles — and a kind of similar result, but for different reasons, other than Sorel's — that actually you had to leave all of these organizations, these syndicates, to struggle, to compete, to be creative, to be left to their own devices. And people like Mussolini and Hitler and other leaders, all the way down, did think about these kinds of tensions, especially the more intellectual Mussolini.

But all of these ideas were floating around in a sea of chaos. Socialism, Völkisch-ism, syndicalism. Anarchism. Nationalism. Authoritarianism. Monarchism, imperialism. Democracy. Liberalism. Debt repayments, crime. Street violence. Paramilitary groups. Chaos. We need some kind of hero.

Chapter Eight: Heroes and Villains; Villains and Heroes

So we have purity, rootedness. Us. The affirmation of struggle, the legitimization of violence. The paramilitarization of civil domestic society. We have crisis and decadence to be fought.

The failures of reforms and parliamentary, squabbling democracy. We have nostalgia for the glory days. We have myth and symbol. Put all of these elements together, and you have a pretty powerful set of values.

There's an ongoing historical debate. Did fascism emerge from below, from the streets, or was it a product of great men of history? The leaders like Hitler and Mussolini, controlling the world from above? In other words, did they fashion the members, the street fighters, the material forces on the ground, or did those historical forces fashion them? Were they constrained by them? Historians come down on different sides on this, but what I've tried to lay out is a kind of social, economic, cultural and political soup — different elements swimming around desperately without shape. Yet it's this that might be seen as most relevant to our times. So much change materially, technologically, ideologically, but no one quite understanding it, no one giving shape to the unwieldy forces all around us. Something like an orchestra of instruments without a conductor.

I personally see it like this. The historical forces come first, like Lego blocks, but it takes a leader, a personality, a heroic figure — maybe at least a group — to put them together into something coherent and lead it forward.

Hitler was obsessed with [Wagner's operas](#) for this reason. They were Germanic and heroic. Wagner was the epic German myth maker. His most well-known work, The Ring Cycle, brings together elements of Germanic and Norse mythology into a great heroic epic. Germany had had a particularly strong attachment to Middle Age mythical heroes as well as those ancient ones. The mythic theorists believed that having these myths was important to society, that it glued together and gave it direction. And I think we often think we're past this, that we're above this today. But just think of the influence of stories like Lord of the Rings, Harry Potter, Star Wars, the Marvel films. These aren't just fictions. They actually structure how we think of the world. We're influenced by them in the subtlest of ways.

It's not that we're all going to be taking rings to Mordor, or that we're going to be wizards. But the subtleties, the psychology and sociology of how the characters deal with certain situations, how they rise above and how they take on the demands around them, the humor, the virtue, the values, the words and the charisma and the facial expressions that they use. These things obviously have an effect on us as social species. We absorb them by mimesis.

But one of the biggest reversals you need to do to understand fascism — the most difficult — is to reverse the heroes and the villains. If you and your people are destitute, in amongst all of these ideas, amongst and maybe from these paramilitary groups coming out of the war, leaders, models to follow, heroes emerge. We have to do what comes most difficult since World War Two. We really try and see ourselves as swimming in these forces and seeing heroes where we know from, again, our comfortable 21st century armchairs, villains.

The first ingredient you need to make a hero is charisma. You need a compelling protagonist. I want to emphasize something else, too. Charisma is everywhere. We often look at history from figures like Hitler or Mussolini's perspectives first, but this history is full of

minor characters who have hundreds or thousands or more followers. These figures are everywhere, and they drive the movement in Italy and in Germany at a kind of local level.

I'll point to two here. [Gabriele D'Annunzio](#), the Italian, and [Karl Lueger](#), the German. There are, of course, many, many others. We'll just use these as examples.

Some historians see D'Annunzio as the very first fascist. After World War One, [he led 200 soldiers into Fiume](#), a city kind of up and above Italy to the east, which is today a part of Croatia, but had a large Italian population and was under the Austrian Empire. Informed by his ultra-nationalism and its irredentism — that Italian ideology that pursued the unredeemed or occupied Italian lands around Italy today — D'Annunzio and his followers occupied Fiume and declared an Italian state.

Many see D'Annunzio as the father of fascism because he brought together many of those initial elements — the ultra-nationalism, the pursuit of a Greater Italy in areas that were mostly ethnically Italian. And crucially, he was a poet, and he knew the power of symbols and slogans and ceremonies. His followers wore [black shirts](#), they idealized violence, and they even used the Roman salute before Mussolini did.

And over in Germany, Hitler was inspired by Karl Lueger. He was an anti-Semitic and populist mayor of Vienna. And also [Dietrich Eckart](#), the founding member of the German Workers Party, the DAP, that was founded in 1919, just at the end of World War One. Eckart was a Völkisch poet. A playwright, he believed in Völkisch German culture, was a powerful moving force. He was also an anti-Semite, and he introduced Hitler to authors like Chamberlain.

The point here is that these charismatic figures take on the historical forces around them. They absorb them, they sometimes build on them, they sometimes innovate — at other times not. But they often then pass them on to a new generation. And occasionally these forces fit with personality, with charisma at the right time and in the right place to create what the philosopher Hegel called world-historical figures. These people that move history structurally, but also through their personality. They will history to move. They put their footprint, their fingerprint on the world.

People were always commenting on Hitler and Mussolini. Hitler's eyes, Mussolini's masculinity, Hitler's powers of rhetoric. Mussolini's biographer Richard Bosworth wrote:

"that followers would remark on his inimitable and incomparable command of gesture, continuing that Mussolini had more than one voice, or rather spoke with a variety of timbres and tones. They varied from the sweet and intimate to the stridently powerful, quote, which reconfirmed the plurality and the multiplicity of his soul."

Again, the plurality and multiplicity of all these forces that we've looked at then goes into the fascist, so I think it's in personality and charisma that we do find the greatest challenge to the kind of themes of the Enlightenment, the rationalism, the materialism that can't really be quantified. It's not a mathematical formulation, it's not a type or a genus that fits in among

the encyclopedia. The great figures, the heroes and the villains of history. The singular. Philosophers like [Emmanuel Levinas](#) have pointed to the magic behind the eyes. For example, the person, the character, the personality who escapes all of our standard and routine and expected ways of categorizing the world. Someone who, because they can withstand or even just avoid the rhythms of the expected, the normal ways of doing things, convention — the radical who can thwart the pressure to conform to the status quo and leap forward.

Mussolini was very aware of a comparison to Napoleon, another world-shaping figure. Hitler had himself portrayed as a knight in shining armor on horseback. These men were both, whether we like to admit it or not, poets of some kind in their own ways.

As we've seen, writers like Jünger and the conservative radicals of the interwar period saw those who fought in the war as a kind of elite with a special connection, a special bond between them. Pilots were widely seen as modern knights in armor, and serious celebrity cults emerged around them. Like the German World War One fighter ace, the [Red Baron, who was said to have shot down 80 planes](#). He was referred to as the Ace of Aces.

Mussolini, in particular, understood the intellectual, the cultural and social heritage before him. He was, after all, inspired in a very, very, very large part by Marx. And he combined all of that heritage, those forces, with a kind of intoxicating love for futurology and technology. He loved engines and cars and planes. Metal. He learned to fly, survived a crash. Bosworth writes: flying something viscerally fascist for Mussolini, and about it — as man flew heavenwards to challenge the very gods.

Mussolini believed very much in the heroic struggle theory of history. His early Marxism and his reading of Darwin taught him that struggle was an engine of change, and then he applied the notion of character, an elitism and willpower and leadership and charisma to that theory.

Writers like [Arthur Bonus](#) believed Nietzsche was the self-fashioning knight that had taught Germans to overcome the mundane. Similar to Sorel, Bonus believed in mythmaking, legends, symbols to spur people into action. The syndicalist Édouard Berth wrote about a, quote, revival of heroic values that appears to be taking place among the younger bourgeoisie. Undoubtedly, something has changed in the bourgeoisie. The bellicose and religious spirit is triumphing over the pacifistic and humanitarian spirit. Like Nietzsche, Berth wrote that he wanted to destroy the quote, power of the average, that is to say, of the democratic, the bourgeois and liberal mediocrity.

I'm jumping ahead a bit. But as fascist groups formed, mythmaking was key. Myths were constructed around martyrs, often that had been killed in street fights, often with communist groups. In Italy, fascists would organize grand funerals lined by files of fascists singing with their sigils and symbols and uniforms.

If we think of Sorel's [mythmaking or mythopoeia](#) as not just a story, but those symbols and songs and place, the culture that went with the myth, then fascism was the ultimate in utilizing this — the Roman salute, the myth of the November criminals that stabbed Germany

in the back. The Nuremberg rallies, the uniforms, the using of modern transport and planes and posters and poems and songs. The propaganda machine in action.

[Later, Goebbels complained that the liberals were copying the Nazis](#), and this was in many ways very true, but it was already too late. Evans puts it like this: Goebbels and his propaganda team aimed to overwhelm the electorate with an unremitting barrage of assaults on their senses. Saturation coverage was to be achieved not only by mass publicity, but also by a concerted campaign of door-knocking and leafleting. Microphones and loudspeakers blasted out Nazi speeches over every public space that could be found.

And for all of these men in the interwar period, action — doing, will — was prioritized over the stultifying, the ineffectual and the lazy thought and talk of rationalism and the Enlightenment, of pen-pushing. It was action and violence over peace. It was nationalism, because that embodied the real physical German or Italian people, over this airy-fairy, universalist, abstract internationalism. It was heroes over democracy.

Chapter Nine: An Idea of Fascism: Bundles and Sticks

Just two years before the First World War, in 1912, [Mussolini became editor of the Socialist journal Avanti!](#) He was the foremost socialist in Italy. He was a committed revolutionary Marxist, and aesthetically Avanti! went hard.

The biggest question mark, the point of analysis, the moment of crucial importance, for me at least, is how Mussolini turned from socialist to fascist. I think anyone on the left particularly would be perplexed by this move, but the key to understanding it is national identity. Remember Sorel's emphasis on myth, story, action as a mobilizing force. Well, just before the war, Sorel became a nationalist syndicalist — somewhere between Marx, Proudhon's anarchism and nationalistic ideas.

The key thing to remember here is that nations — identifiable groups with distinctive cultures, languages, heritages, a history — were under the yoke of empires. Imagine being one of the hundreds of thousands of Italians that lived under Austro-Hungarian rule in the north of what is now Italy. Of course we should be uniting all Italians. Of course Italians should be free, self-determining, one people. In other words, nationalism was in many ways a progressive cause.

On the other hand, when [Italy was united in 1860, only — incredibly — about 2.5% of Italians even spoke Italian](#). The peasantry and large parts of the country had no real idea about Italian national identity. The history, the culture and the greatness and the goals that nationalists wanted to stoke. So almost everyone except the internationalist left believed that fostering and incubating this national culture was key to Italian greatness.

On top of this, there's the national empire question. What happens when France and Britain carve up Africa and leave you nothing? The dregs, the crumbs. Belgium had the Congo.

What did Italy have? Fragility. Did it not deserve a seat at the imperial table? Some said that Italy was the least of the great powers, a sick man of Europe.

In 1904, [Mussolini had attended lectures of Vilfredo Pareto](#), one of the most famous intellectuals of the period. Pareto believed in creative elites, those who shaped the world by will, dynamism and intellectual creativity. He's famed now for the Pareto principle — that the 20% of the people at the top, the elites, produce 80% of the results. Pareto believed that elites, because of this, inevitably ruled.

Remember? Many believed that the proletariat was failing in their revolutionary mission that Marx had set for them. Nothing was happening except socialists were giving in to liberals and liberal demands and accepting small, piecemeal reforms. They were being seduced by liberals and parliamentarians. They were becoming puppets of the elites. And so something had to change.

Mussolini was a maximalist. He believed in revolution over reform. But he was also growing skeptical of the revolutionary power and agency of the working class, and tired of the reformist tendencies of so-called socialists. He wrote, quote, we only hope that the party returns to its primordial methods of struggle, and that it directs an implacable fighting spirit against the constituted order, without dirtying its hands with political or financial deals.

Many radicals agreed. For syndicalists, Sternhell writes:

"little by little, the centrality of class struggle in the credo of the movement was replaced by elitist conceptions and a hope of raising the moral level of the working class. A kind of vulgar determinism was replaced with an idea of elite leadership, of taking the reins through the means of symbols and ideas. Charisma with choice."

There was a syndicalist party in Italy, the [USI, the Unione Sindacale Italiana](#). It was a major force in Italian politics, and it had 100,000 members by the end of 1912. It won seats in Parliament, and slowly, especially over the [Biennio Rosso](#), became more and more nationalistic.

Mussolini was moving slowly away from the determinism and materialism of Marx. He believed in the power of ideas, intellectualism and will, and the need to cultivate Italian symbolic national identity. He encouraged Italians to read Nietzsche in Avanti! He wrote in one article, quote, it is faith which moves mountains because it gives the illusion that the mountains move. Illusion is perhaps the only reality in life. Above all.

Mussolini hated parliaments. He hated the talking shop, and he believed that action was the key to change. Sternhell puts it like this:

"In Italy, the synthesis of nationalism with revolutionary syndicalism was based on the same principles as in France. On the one hand, the rejection of democracy, Marxism, liberalism, the so-called bourgeois values, the 18th century heritage, internationalism and pacifism. On the other hand, a cult of heroism, vitalism and violence."

A similar move would be made in Germany. The founder of the German Workers Party in 1919, a guy called [Anton Drexler](#), was a socialist — but a National Socialist. While there was less of a syndicalist influence here, if any, much more of a Völkisch one. The move made is kind of rationally, logically similar. Once you appendage nationalist, you invite the particular elements — symbols, ideas, myths, poems, music — of your own national culture into socialism as a mobilizing force.

For these Marxists, nations are a construct, an idea. Flags, symbols, language — forms of nonsense. And National Socialists, of course — there was a lot of disagreement here. They often agreed, but they believed, as in Germany, that nations were more than ideas. They were ideas, but they were transcendent, mystical, spiritual. Maybe.

Either way, National Socialists in Italy and Germany began reversing the usual Marxist materialism. They believed you put the idea of the nation first. One nationalist wrote:

"The nation is above classes, and all considerations of class should give way before things of a national character."

And then the summer of 1914 changed everything. First, in June, there was that Red Week that we talked about. And then second, in July, just a month after, the First World War broke out.

The war split the left in Italy. The Italian Socialist Party, the PSI, were [internationalists](#). They were [universalists](#). They believed, as Marx had written, that the working man has no country. They were the second biggest bloc in Parliament, and Mussolini was a member. The position was neutrality. Mussolini wrote that the Italian proletariat must not spill a single drop of blood for a cause which was not its own. He wrote in favor of absolute neutrality.

He did, though, begin to allow supporters of the war, and those who encouraged the joining of the war, to publish in his magazine. In Avanti! — but always the unorthodox Marxist. He tentatively started to change his position. He moved more and more towards an interventionist one. He was, after all, by inclination a fighter, and he kept watching the proletariat fail to take power. They just didn't have it in them, he thought. He thought they were poor revolutionaries. And the revolution was something that required action and violence. He was beginning to see the war as a chance to build up Italy and to radicalize the masses.

Not only most socialists, but most Italians supported Italian neutrality. However, the pressure from those who wanted expansionism — who thought that Italy needed industrial raw materials to thrive, to build up its industrial capacity, mostly from the center-right — saw a huge opportunity in the war. War was a chance to regain those lost lands. The unredeemed lands, the *terre irredente*, plus maybe a few colonies elsewhere, maybe an [expansion of Italy around the Mediterranean basin](#). Italy as the great power in the middle of the Med, the African north coast as a garden.

Mussolini edged towards this position. He wrote: We have the privilege of living at the most tragic hour in world history. Do we, as men and as socialists, want to be inert spectators of this huge drama? Or do we want to be, in some way, in some sense, the protagonists?

It all aligned with Mussolini's view of action over talking, of people doing things over simple materialism. Many socialists thought about this question, so it wasn't a fringe one. One disagreed with Mussolini, writing:

"Let the government blow up the ship. The explosion will sweep them away. Down with war. Long live the revolution!"

I want to introduce this wonderfully mustached character briefly. His name was [Alceste De Ambris](#). Remember when we talked about charisma, heroism, leadership? Well, this guy was a major figure in the Italian syndicalist movement. And he's great because he demonstrates the ambiguities of the left and the right in this period. How difficult this constellation of ideas, this soup, was.

He was on the left. He moved from socialism to syndicalism, believing that the state was a waste of time. The proletariat, he thought, should win power through unions and take over corporate syndicates. But he was an interventionist. He supported [D'Annunzio in Fiume](#), wrote the constitution, which guaranteed free press, free thought, equality and equal-weight, free schools. Again, a man of the left. But he was on the nationalist left.

In fact, he founded a very short-lived national syndicalist splinter group in support of joining the war, and it was called the [Fascio Rivoluzionario d'Azione Internazionalista](#). And I've probably entirely butchered that. But note the key word — fascio. And in that — revolutionary, anti-internationalist. And this attracted none other than Mussolini. A small splinter group.

So at this point, these two men are both pretty left. The only difference? It would be a left focused on Italy joining the war, rather than an Italy and a [socialist Italy joining the Bolsheviks](#) and joining an internationalist movement. And it was a left in favor of a war to make Italy into a greater power than it already was. And again, remember, there were Italians under the Austrian Empire. So you could see this as a war of liberation.

Sternhell put it like this:

"The myth of the Revolutionary War was an instrument of political mobilization, and a call for action to take society out of its immobility. The revolutionary syndicalists therefore denounced all those who opposed the war — whether liberals, reformist socialists or anarchists — as conservatives."

But there was a crucial difference between the syndicalists and the socialists. The syndicalists believed you could kind of fuse the bourgeoisie and the proletariat into one class. The producer class. Sternhell says that it now appeared that they not only regarded themselves as hostile to the bourgeoisie, but preferred sharing with it a wealthier society to

inheriting from it a poorer one. This was the essential reason for their anti-Bolshevism — the great Bolshevism, which causes the collapse of the bourgeois economic regime, disintegrates every productive organism, creates disorder in the industrial sector and leads to disorder and poverty. It is the most anti-socialist and most anti-proletarian phenomenon in the world.

Remember, these were — and I use this term very vaguely — like idealists in a sense, rather than materialists. They might have had a complex relationship between the two, but they believed — even if they were somehow derived from a material base — ultimately they believed in culture, ideas, leaders, myths, personalities, charisma, symbols as the moving force. And people who spun all that together, who cooked it into a recipe and led it.

Mussolini again was moving closer and closer to this position. He wrote: "he wanted to create an Italian soul." He said: "in loving their own nationality, it is not mandatory for them to hate the others. Rather, harmonic development and the brotherhood of all nations." This is the socialist ideal.

At this point he wanted to have his cake and eat it too. He was trying to synthesize the different trends and ideologies around him. He wanted to be a socialist and a nationalist, it seems.

Things started to move quickly. He continued writing and speaking in support of nationalism. In October, he stepped down from Avanti! In November, he was expelled from the Socialist Party. And in December he gave this speech. He said: "The nation has not disappeared. Class reveals itself as a collection of interests, but the nation is a history of sentiments, traditions, language, culture and race." Class can become an integral part of the nation, but the one cannot eclipse the other. The class struggle is a vain formula without effect and consequence. Wherever one finds a people that has not integrated itself into its proper linguistic and racial confines. Where the national problem has not been definitely resolved. In such circumstances, the class movement finds itself impaired by an inauspicious historic climate.

He immediately began a new paper, [Il Popolo d'Italia](#). But he addressed socialists in it. Especially at first, he said:

"Whatever happens, you won't lose me. 12 years of my life in the party ought to be sufficient guarantee of my socialist faith. Socialism is in my very blood."

But he slowly became, like the syndicalists, an anti-Bolshevik and maybe an anti-Marxist. Or at least if he retained some Marxism, it was a very particular type of Marxist interpretation. When and whether he lost it entirely — it's difficult to know. But in 1918, the paper dropped its socialist label and replaced it with "producers" as a label.

Mussolini was never a member of the syndicalist party. But like converging roads, the two met. Sternhell writes: "at the moment the war broke out, the ideological development of revolutionary syndicalism had reached the point of no return." The socialist-nationalist

synthesis had come to fruition in the years before August 1914, but it's clear that this terrible ordeal, meaning the First World War, greatly accelerated its evolution.

Again, all of these forces drove along these converging roads — the nation, the myths, the symbols, the idea of struggle and the glorification of action and violence. And they all culminated in Mussolini accepting the draft in 1915. He served two years, was wounded by shrapnel. And at around the same time, [Adolf Hitler was temporarily blinded by mustard gas](#), both serving, of course, in the First World War. And both figures became part of that symbolic generation, those that had sacrificed, that had served heroically for their nation.

Again, you don't have fascism, at least not in the same way, without World War One.

Chapter Ten: Fascism Developed

The development of fascism isn't easily understandable because it isn't straightforward. In many movements, you have a set of ideas — Marx or civil rights. Then you have leaders. You have a Lenin or a Martin Luther King, and then you have followers. But with fascism, you have these very real, physical, material groups on the ground, very violent, very tough, very hard. Mostly these veterans returning from war. And then you have leadership which is strong-minded, maybe intellectual, more idealist, but without a single set of coherent doctrines, more driven by personality and a kind of combination of lots of ideas that are floating around. And then these two things — the kind of violent materialism of the boots on the ground, the power of the groups, and the intellectualism of the leaders, the ideas — they sort of come closer together in a dance, join with each other, influence each other.

Remember the Arditi, D'Annunzio, the Blackshirts, the slogans, the poetry, the veteran groups in Germany and many, many others. Many ordinary people at home getting on with their lives. So the governments in Italy and Germany — this is weak — which was just a truism. No one could get anything done. There were too many groups in Parliament, too much bickering, too many directions. And the countries both looked like they were being torn apart in all of these different directions.

And so many of these groups, like the Arditi, became like sources of power. They banded closer together. And the obvious enemy of the nationalism of these groups — that have been marinating for centuries and developing and getting stronger and stronger across the 19th century, and then was cooked and purified in the cauldron of the First World War — the obvious enemy to that particularism, that nationalism, that emphasizing of there being something special about the particular national people. The obvious enemy was internationalism, universalism, [Bolshevism](#).

In defense of that Italianism. And that's where the violence or physicality of those groups directed their very powerful raw energy. Bosworth says of the Arditi that at the front, they had intrepidly engaged in the gymnastics of war. Manly, in every sense, they fused thought,

beauty and action. A new aristocracy. They were the enemies of traitors everywhere they might hide.

Another key moment, along with Mussolini's change, was happening in the countryside around the Po Valley in the north, in many areas in Italy. The socialists were de facto in control, and it was very, very real, very bloody class warfare. That was very kind of localized and messy and gang-ish. And it happened across many dimensions — in strikes and protests and real violence between landowners and workers and influential politicians. It was messy, to put it lightly.

The Arditi, when they came back from the war, disillusioned, radicalized by violence and led by their former officers — and they joined groups that became known as the squadristi or squadristo, who roamed the countryside. They were groups of 30 to 50 men, much better at organized violence than the socialists, much better trained militarily. They roamed around the countryside looking for fights. They became known for pouring castor oil on their enemies. They utilized open-bed army trucks and military weapons.

Violence spread rapidly. Fascist squads armed themselves with cudgels and truncheons. They were mostly clean-shaven. They wore black. Some had guns. Leaders became known as the ras. They were all soldiers from the war. And they went out on expeditions to find targets, sometimes for days on end in trucks. It was the war mirrored domestically. It was a paramilitary mirroring of wartime experience.

Payne writes that: "the new mass fascism had not been created by Mussolini so much as it had sprung up around him in the rural areas of the north." The historian [Cesare Rossi](#) also argued that everything about fascism came up from below, from these groups, or from D'Annunzio and his men.

And on top of this, these men were often supported financially by landowners. But we have to remember that fascio just means bundle of sticks, because at this point they weren't really following a formed ideology at all. They were just a bundle. They were groups roaming and fighting. They were often, usually, nationalist Italians, anti-Bolshevik, militarist, mostly. So there was a kind of outline forming, and some might even be syndicalist or have syndicalist sympathies. But remember, many syndicalists were also much more firmly on the left, while many others moved more to the nationalist right, but still retained a kind of radical socialist unionism. There were lots of splits. It was, to understate it, not a simple situation, but that added to the draw of some kind of order. That order could be an ideology in itself.

On top of this, [fascio was just a general term in Italy, adopted by many groups as far back as the 1870s](#). But in the immediate aftermath of the war, it became more closely connected to these groups. And as Mussolini moved towards them like a magnet to intellectual ideas, they moved towards leaders like Mussolini and the local ones.

In the fascist experience, [Edward Tannenbaum](#) puts it like this:

"Although many squad leaders were to accept subsidies from the big landowners and businessmen, they did not abandon that ultimate goal of making their own revolution. A number of the revolutionary syndicalists in the original fascist movement were to play a major role in organizing counter-unions of agricultural workers."

But by the end of 1920, Mussolini began taking his cues from the squadristi.

In March of 1919, this group came together officially as the [Fasci Italiani di Combattimento in Milan](#), led by Mussolini. He rejected political parties. He called for a national revolution, for universal suffrage, the abolition of the Senate, an eight-hour working day, worker participation in industrial management, pension plans, and, quote, the partial expropriation of all wealth.

In other words, it all sounded very economically and socially left, but it was a syndicalist left. And this is why I say it's unclear when and if Mussolini abandoned his Marxism entirely. Of course, he was nothing like a traditional Marxist, and we balk at thinking of him like a leftist today. But in the beginning at least, it seems like the intention was still there. And maybe in some back corner of his mind, it always was.

It's hard to know what motivates people's thinking. He may have thought this was a path that would ultimately lead to the kind of working class emancipation that he learned from Marxism — eventually — but that because the proletariat was failing at rising up, it needed many more decades of leadership and bourgeois industrial development. It's hard to know, even from explicit writings, what he was thinking at this point.

One syndicalist theorist, [Sergio Panunzio](#), wrote a program of action at the same time. Remember, this was all very loose. There were lots of different people doing different things. But the [program of action had articles](#) like: Article 5 — the entire population be divided into organic classes. Article 6 — the classes be organized into corporations. Article 7 — the administration of social matters be transferred to the corporations.

He envisaged a syndicalist corporatist nation where everything was very neatly organized into groups that had priority over the chaos of individualism. Sternhell writes that owing to the fact that each person was a member of a syndicate-corporation, the nation would be made up of syndicates and no longer of individuals solely concerned with their personal profit.

Later, syndicalist-then-fascist [Augusto Lanzillo](#) said that the aim was to reconstitute the proletariat on the basis of spiritual liberty and to animate it with the breath of creative violence. This would be the true revolution that would mold the forms of the Italy of tomorrow.

But there was a problem. Most on the left were still socialists, and the squadristi — they were funded by large landowners, which Mussolini tried to keep a secret. Remember, this is someone who had just said very recently that socialism was in his blood.

And this is another difficult ambiguity. When did he change? Had he changed yet? Did he know which direction he was going in? It's really difficult in history to get a very real, precise

grip on this. Commentators noticed that as far back as 1914, he began getting a taste for expensive hobbies. Horse riding, fast cars, nice food. His biographer, [Patricia Bosworth](#), jumps around on the issue. Was he tainting himself? Maybe. Was he corrupt? Bosworth doesn't think so. Others might.

Maybe Mussolini was playing a double game. Or likely he sensed something rising up in him that seemed to synthesize well with other powerful people around him, too. And the groups on the ground — we could call this a new commonality, something new in common with many people emerging as a social group, a social force.

Mussolini himself wrote: "every state-owned concern is an economic disaster. Again, he hated the chatter of Parliament." He said: "as far as economics is concerned, we are liberals, because we believe that the national economy cannot be usefully entrusted to collective or governmental and bureaucratic organizations."

So it seems by now he's abandoned that classical Marxism entirely. Remember he was anti-state, anti-parliament, anti-Bolshevik. And so the only route seemed to be through the unions and the corporations. Mussolini wrote:

"the state turned into a monarch when it tried to be a banker, a lender, a gambling housekeeper, a seaman, a bandit, an insurer, a postman, a railway worker, an impresario, an industrialist, a teacher, a tobacco shop owner, a judge, a gambler and a tax man."

And Bosworth puts it like this.

"The Fascists, Mussolini explained, when they committed eventually to a solution whereby land was acquired by those who worked it. However, any move towards greater social equality would be slow. It would only be achieved with national agreement and so without any damage to the economy."

Mussolini said that the hour of syndicalism had arrived. A third way between capitalism and communism, a pragmatism of producers and hard workers and those loyal to Italy — over class division, over universalism, over Bolshevism. In other words, Mussolini was becoming a kind of pragmatist mongrel. And I don't mean that in a negative sense. I just mean, you know, he was selecting from lots of ideas around him, depending on what suited either him or the moment.

More politically, he could do or say or promise anything, as long as it was in service to some nebulous idea of Italy and Italians. And you can fit so much into that, depending on who you're talking to. And on top of this, he was now riding a wave of squadristi — a wave no one could completely control.

I'm not sure there's a reason to see him as a corrupted or cynical figure. In many ways, his principle of Italianism and everything that embodied led the way. But in doing so, he was becoming all things to all people and saying nothing to anyone. He could slip between stuff.

This is the problem with pragmatism more broadly. And this is why, right here, this might be the beginning of totalitarianism. The idea that the will of the leader is all that counts. A kind of personalist, embodied pragmatism justified by an idea of Italy and supported by extreme paramilitary violence.

As that violence intensified, the fascist groups got bolder, and the country was descending into what looked like either civil war or revolution. The extremes battling on the streets and an ineffectual center able to do almost nothing. [Skirmishes took place all over the country, and Mussolini endorsed this violence](#). He wrote in 1920:

"The reality is this — the Socialist Party is a Russian army encamped in Italy, and against this foreign enemy, Fascists have launched a guerrilla war and they will conduct it with exceptional seriousness."

The futurist [Filippo Tommaso Marinetti](#) and fascist leader [Cesare Maria De Vecchi marched to the Avanti! headquarters and ransacked it](#), destroying documents and equipment. What's incredible about this situation is that socialists were still dominant in elections, but these elections were then often interrupted by fascists with beatings and shootings and general intimidation.

One eyewitness recalled:

"it seemed like the piazza was covered in bodies which were lying everywhere. It was absurd. Hard to believe. Apocalyptic."

In many cases, fascists bullied elected officials out of office. They scared people from running for office and voting. The police often ignored what was happening or took the side of fascists explicitly. High-profile socialists were kidnapped, tortured, beaten or killed. One was forced to walk around town with a placard around his neck that read: You must serve the Fatherland, and I am a deserter.

In the phrase of one historian, this was a terrorist dictatorship emerging from the streets. It was a government by violence, forcing democracy out by force, leaving shadowy groups as blunt objects ready to take over. One onlooker said that they were crazy. He said: it appears the war has taught people to kill.

Then violence reached Parliament. Here's John Foot on this:

"Misiano, a deputy since 1919, was sitting in the so-called transatlantic corridor in parliament outside the chamber when the fascist deputy [Silvio Gai](#) came up to him. "Are you Misiano?" he asked. [Misiano](#) replied in the affirmative. "Then get out," said Gai. Misiano refused to leave, saying that he had been voted in to serve as a deputy. Gai stated that his voters had elected him to kick Misiano out. Gai then attacked Misiano after the familiar battle cry of fascists, from the war: "A noi!" — meaning "Fascists! It is down to us!" A number of armed fascists, including [Giuseppe Bottai](#), surrounded Misiano and began pushing him towards the exit."

This is a fascinating contradiction within democracy. This idea that he had the democratic power because of the blunt force of fascists behind him, that blunt force could be as important in a kind of weird, democratic way as the ballot box could be. That if my force, backed up by these numerous, you know, tens of thousands, hundreds of thousands of people around the country, could lead into Parliament and literally force you out. Right? Is that not some kind of weird, absurd, grotesque will of the people? This is the way that they thought.

Terror reigned. Socialists were treated. People were in fear. One writer put it like this:

"The newspapers of the labor movement are set on fire, and the piazzas and consumer co-operatives are burned and agricultural leagues are dissolved. While they — the fascists — kill and laugh, laugh and kill."

The leading socialist [Giacomo Matteotti](#) talked in Parliament about what was happening. He said:

"It happened in the dead of night, in small villages. Houses of union officials would be surrounded by 20 to 100 armed men, threatening to burn the house if he didn't come out. Then they take him off. Torture him, mock-murder him, sometimes. Release him, other times, kill him."

In 1924, Matteotti himself was bundled into the back of a car, stabbed, and his body dumped outside Rome.

By 1921, fascist groups de facto controlled the streets in much of the north of Italy, and in November, the paramilitary group was transformed by Mussolini into the PNF — the [National Fascist Party](#). There were around a quarter of a million members, taking numbers from the socialists, whose membership declined over the period.

One socialist wrote:

"Turn after turn, destruction threatened terror at the sixty small municipalities of the province. One by one, and in about 2 or 3 weeks, we have been invaded by hundreds of hooligans. During the day, beating all those who have been indicated as being socialists by local agrarians, ransacking buildings, breaking up the furniture and taking away everything they find. At night, moving in groups, wearing masks and holding muskets, they shoot at random in the streets and throw bombs, break into the houses. If whoever is part of a municipal administration, of a league, of a co-operative, and so on — and surrounded by the unspeakable screams of women and children — they threaten violently, extort declarations, impose shameful things, or force people to desperately run away into the countryside."

Fascism had arrived.

Chapter Eleven: German Copycats

The majority of Germans despised the Weimar Republic. Hitler, of course, was one of them. Remember the interwar settlement, the restricting of the army which Hitler had learned to love during World War One? His band of brothers, the hyperinflation, the chaos, the threats — imagined and real — of socialism and Bolshevism in the East, and the philosophy of the Volk, of corporatism, of authoritarianism, of return to some kind of order.

Now there's one thing that particularly irked Hitler. It was the military having to negotiate with Soviet councils that were popping up across Germany in the aftermath of the First World War and the revolutions going on. Some wanted to join Russia. Others cooperated with the military to bring some order and oppose Bolshevism.

After fighting in the war, being hospitalized in a gas attack, and having rejected the modern, multicultural, chaotic city of Vienna, Hitler attended army lectures that were anti-socialist, Pan-Germanic and of course, Völkisch. His superiors were so impressed with him that they made him an instructor. He was sent to nationalist meetings. He lectured to soldiers about anti-communism and pan-nationalism, and both Hitler himself and his superiors quickly discovered an incredible talent for speaking to crowds.

The army asked Hitler to join the [DAP](#), a small German Workers Party startup, to infiltrate and gather information and to make connections. The DAP was Pan-German, nationalistic, anti-Semitic, populist, Völkisch and, early on, anti-capitalist. The 1920 party program had policies for pension plans, nationalizing trusts, sharing profits in key industries, and land reform.

But Hitler quickly became the star of the small party, which only had around 50 members. He left the army and quickly moved up the ranks. I'm not going to try the tired old path here. There are plenty of documentaries and videos about the rise of the Nazis out there. What's important for us? Well, these trends we've already identified, and how they appealed and created and made ordinary Germans into the first fascists.

First and foremost, like Italy, the interwar paramilitarization of Germany. We talked about the Steel Helmets, the Freikorps and the communist Red Front Fighters' League. The quote unquote quasi-guerrilla warfare that was the result of all of this. And Hitler and the DAP, which then became the NSDAP, the [National Socialist German Workers Party](#), built up the [SA, the paramilitary Brownshirts](#) that emerged out of all of this interwar mystification of the military.

What's key is how the populist mass-appeal Brownshirts appealed to young Germans looking for some kind of belonging, some kind of order. This was a group that reached 4 million members, organized from the bottom up, larger than the German army itself. That says so much.

[Ernst Röhm](#), their leader, had ties to these paramilitary Freikorps and built the Brownshirts up into a so-called people's army to protect and to fight for the NSDAP and for German

nationalism. Hitler later said that, quote, politics back then was made on the street, and that he'd searched in particular for men of brutality. In 1921 he said: We must be strong not only in words, but in deeds against our enemy, the Jew.

Röhm was a man of violence. The first sentence of his autobiography is: I am a soldier. He loved fighting, brawling, drinking, misogyny, saying he was contemptuous of civilians. And this, I think, is key. He was independent in many ways from Hitler — one of the few — because his power came from below, from the Brownshirts, from the SA.

And similarly, in Italy, Mussolini was riding this wave of squadristi, made somewhat dependent on the regional ras leadership in Italy, but they were also kind of ground-up, bottom-up phenomena. These ras leaders were in turn riding this bottom-up paramilitary grouping. One revealing SA slogan was: "We'll beat our way to the top."

In Germany, one witness remembers 400 Brownshirts turning up at a rival meeting. He said, quote: "One after the other, our four speakers had their say, interrupted by furious howling and catcalls. But when in the ensuing discussion, an interlocutor was reprimanded for saying, 'We don't want the brown plague in our beautiful town,' tumult broke out." What followed was a battle with beer steins, chairs and the like. In two minutes, the hall was demolished and everyone cleared out. We had to take back seven heavily injured comrades that day, and there were rocks thrown at us from occasional assaults in spite of the police protection.

Like in Italy, paramilitary violence grew. Communists were beaten and murdered. Hundreds were killed on both sides. One witness remembers a fight when communists stormed a Nazi meeting. He said:

"Blackjacks, brass knuckles, clubs, heavy buckle belts, glasses and bottles were the weapons used. Pieces of glass and chairs hurtled over the heads of the audience. Men from both sides broke off chair legs and used them as bludgeons. Women fainted in the crash and scream of battle. Already dozens of heads and faces were bleeding. Clothes were torn as the fighters, dodged by maddened masses of terrified but helpless spectators. The groups fought like lions. Systematically, they pressed us towards the main exit. The band struck up a martial tune. Hermann Göring stood calmly on the stage. His fists on his hips."

Hitler was riding a wave that he couldn't really steer. He was trying to steer it, and in some sense he could change its direction. But it was a wave, a wave pulling in different directions. Later, the Brownshirts' leader, Ernst Röhm, wanted to use the Brownshirts to replace the army, to nationalize industries, and to continue a bottom-up populist Volk, people's revolution. A wing of the young Nazi Party led by [Gregor Strasser](#) was much more left-wing. All were Völkisch, but some were more populist, some were more socialist, and some were more elitist, some more economically to the left.

But later, most of them, or at least the most dangerous ones to Hitler, were expelled or murdered by him in the [Night of the Long Knives](#).

What's interesting about this moment, and bear with me here, is that radicals were expelled, leaving Hitler somewhat in the center. His policies were not much different, at least the policies he espoused officially, than the conservative nationalists of the period. So what was the difference?

Most people, like in Italy, wanted radical change. But like Mussolini, Hitler did not want to revolutionize and radically change the economic base — except for some minor reforms, some minor tweaks. Some Nazis, like some fascists, did want more radical revolutionary change to the economics. But both Hitler and Mussolini became kind of pragmatists.

So if that's true, where would the radical change come from? It would be cultural, institutional, national — to create, and this was a goal, a new spiritual German — all under the threat and the coercion of authoritarian violence. Hitler found that antisemitism was the most uniting force to all sides and to the base. It had a kind of unifying power. It provided an ideology, a glue. It animated the most people. It appealed to all prejudices.

Mosse writes that with this issue, Hitler had found the basis for uniting emotionally and ideologically the small and fanatical party, an issue which transcended the insoluble problem of nationalism versus socialism. Hitler's revolution for Germany was going to be a cultural revolution, a revolution, in Mosse's phrase, of attitudes and feelings, to create a new German — defined very selectively. Most of all against the Jew, who could be both a greedy capitalist and an international Bolshevik. At the same time, it was the perfect foil to redirect German attitudes, German culture, German spirit into some proactive, novel, new force. The Jew was perfect for this because with the Jew, the enemy could be everywhere.

As a result, Evans writes:

"the Nazi Party support amongst middling and small landowners skyrocketed. Soon farmers' sons were providing the manpower for stormtrooper units being dispatched to fight the communists in the big cities."

Fascism is [ultranationalist populism](#). The political theorist [Roger Griffin](#) called fascism [palingenetic](#) — basically a fancy word for national rebirth — ultra-nationalism. The renewal of past national glory.

Like in Italy, the rise of the Nazis was fueled by the *terre irredente* — that's an Italian phrase, but the point was that there were ethnic Germans living under foreign rule, under occupation. Even the Germans had been, again, stabbed in the back. They were being oppressed. That there were enemies within and without. The eternal struggle was real. If you're struggling to feed your family and you see people buying bread with wheelbarrows of money, would you not be a part of this movement?

Both Hitler and Mussolini knew the power of propaganda. Mussolini, with his background in journalism, and Hitler as an artist, inspired by musicians like Wagner and poets like D'Annunzio. They used symbols, emotions, slogans, uniforms, rallies, songs, radio — all to create a powerful mood, a set of mobilizing passions.

This is what distinguished fascists from conservatives. Fascists targeted and brought in the people. The masses. Conservatives were elitists. They were kind of separatists in this sense. They distrusted the masses, the little people, who they believed should be led. Mass movements, they thought, were to be feared as anarchic, chaotic, base. Fascists instead were radical. In this sense, they were new in that they accepted you in, they brought you in, they invited you in, and they made you part of something bigger.

And so over the 1920s, the Nazi Party grew into the largest party in Germany. Like Italy, the center shrank to almost nothing, squeezed out by both sides. [But the country was so divided that it wasn't possible to get a majority in the Reichstag](#). Over and over again, sessions ended in uproar and arguments. [In 1931, the Reichstag couldn't sit for six months](#).

Political power moved to [President Hindenburg](#), who took over with emergency decrees, and he ruled with his inner nationalist circle for much of the time.

Something people often miss, I think, is that the Weimar Republic was pretty much doomed from the start — that the left wanted to overthrow it. The communists wanted it down. And the right, of course, did too — including its president, its leader, Hindenburg. He hated democracy and wanted to return to the Second Reich.

The conservatives, though, they didn't have the numbers and they needed the Nazis' help. The route to achieving this was through the Weimar Constitution itself. It was written into it through [Article 48](#) — to allow the president to bypass the Reichstag and rule by decree in case of stalemate or emergency in Parliament, which of course was happening over and over.

But this is a dangerous clause because of the ambiguity of the word emergency, and really points to the technical, nuanced attention to detail needed in constitutional writing. That emergency — that Article 48 — was abused across the Weimar years before the Nazis even got close to power. The very first Social Democrat president, [Friedrich Ebert, used it 136 times](#).

Evans writes:

"that there were virtually no effective safeguards against an abuse of Article 48, since the president could threaten to use the power given to him by [Article 25](#) to dissolve the Reichstag should it reject a presidential decree."

On top of this, an amendment to the constitution with a two-thirds majority could, in effect, end democracy — could rewrite the Constitution. Of course, this is very common, but the combination of Article 48 and Article 25 that could kick all power into the Presidential Executive Office made this even more unstable.

Government after government and cabinet after cabinet failed to govern. No-confidence votes, rules by decree and other legal mechanisms toppled each successive cabinet.

Eventually, at an impasse in January of 1933, [President Hindenburg appointed Hitler as Chancellor](#) in an attempt to co-opt the Nazi movement, but by giving most cabinet seats to Hindenburg's allies, authoritarians and old regime traditionalists like von Papen, Hindenburg hoped, as von Papen put it, to make Hitler squeak. It was a power play.

But the rallies that followed looked like a bit more than squeaking. [18,000 Brownshirts and 40,000 ordinary Germans joined a march celebrating Hitler's big moment](#) — his appointment. One onlooker wrote that 20,000 Brownshirts followed one another like waves in the sea. Their faces shone with enthusiasm in the light of the torches. For our leader, our Reich Chancellor Adolf Hitler. A threefold Heil. They sang: The Republic is shit. Next to us, a little boy, three years of age, raised his tiny hand again and again. Heil Hitler! Heil Hitler! "Death to the Jews" was also sometimes called out. And they sang of the blood of the Jews, which would squirt from their knives.

Another saw a man struck by a Brownshirt, and he later remembered this about the incident, and states:

"The horror it inspired in me was almost imperceptibly spiced with an intoxicating joy. 'We want to die for the flag,' the torch bearers had sung. I was overcome with a burning desire to belong to these people, for whom it was a matter of death and life. I wanted to escape from my childish, narrow life, and I wanted to attach myself to something that was great and fundamental."

Communists staged strikes, demonstrations and counter-marched. Violence increased. Things snowballed. Communists were murdered on the streets. Some were tortured. The new coalition cracked down on freedom of speech. It banned social democratic newspapers and communist meetings and communist press. The courts, most of whom were made up of old regime authoritarian nationalist loyalists, almost always sided with the fascists.

[When the Communist Party claimed 130,000 members had been arrested and 2,500 murdered](#), like in Italy, fascists had grown such a dynamic mass movement, came to institutions in the paramilitary groups on the ground, that all that was left to do was to destroy democracy somehow from within.

Chapter Twelve: Conservatives, Crisis, and Power

Just before Mussolini took power, the composition of Italian Parliament looked like this. You see two big blocs on either side. The socialists as the biggest party on one side, the center, roughly, as the biggest bloc, but divided between many parties and largely ineffectual for that reason. And then the conservative nationalists, including the PNF, the fascists — smaller on the right. In the previous election, the fascists had won just two seats. How do we explain their dominance then?

First, this last election was the year before the famous [March on Rome](#). The PNF skyrocketed to having as many members as the socialists across this period. Second, the socialists believed that Italy wasn't developed enough for a revolution and so hesitated. And finally, the squadristi used blunt, violent force at local elections to intimidate and begin to control through force and violence local affairs.

To take one example, Foot says:

"40 councillors have been elected in Cremona, but the quiet democratic procedure was completely ignored by the local fascists. They did not recognize elections. In that same month, local fascist leader and ras Roberto Farinacci insisted that he be allowed to speak as the 41st councillor. He told them he had elected himself."

The politician reformist [Claudio Treves](#) told the Italian parliament that the state has abandoned all its power to the aggressors. A state has formed within the state. A private army has formed alongside the national army.

Later on, the Nazis needed to win before their real terror could begin, although it had started before. But in Italy, the fascist terror for a large part came before power and actually let them into power.

In October [1922, Mussolini told a crowd in Naples that we want to become the state](#). He then said:

"Either they give us the government or we will take it by descending on Rome."

Then, back in [Cremona](#), fascists seized a police station and post office. The fascists began to organize a march on the capital. The king then had a choice: send in the army or accept fascist rule.

One marshal told the king:

"Your Majesty, the army will do its duty. However, it would be well not to put it to the test."

Now, this is obviously a choke point, but most said at the time, and historians have since mostly agreed, that the army could actually have easily stopped the march. If the politicians and the king had had the will to do so. One commentator said that with the use of martial law and the deployment of regular armed forces, it would have taken 48 hours or even less to round up the fascists.

But the King, [King Victor Emmanuel the Third](#), stood down. Many since have debated why. Was he weak, afraid of civil war? Or did he simply agree, in at least a large part, on many matters with the fascists? We can never know for sure.

But the key point is this: in both Italy and Germany, fascists could not win power without some kind of conservative establishment support.

Mussolini took the night train to Rome. Fascists marched, quote unquote — because in reality, they drove and walked and just traveled down to the capital. They got trains as well. Many were in their army uniforms from the war, with the medals. And with the King's agreement, fascists took power.

But again, it was a strange type of compromise in power. The king still in place. Parliament still in place. Most institutions left in place, at least overnight. Mussolini threatened and cajoled Parliament, particularly the center, into supporting him, and he took full powers slowly. Many socialists continued to be beaten, tortured and sometimes killed. Now with impunity, the squadristi had become the state.

Foot writes that:

"a novel and highly effective form of political activity was being experimented with for the first time. A militia party. In Italy, fascism existed in hybrid form with the liberal institutions that preceded it. It was not a full revolution and so required the cooperation of these institutions."

The [Fascist Grand Council](#) was new and outside of the existing system, as was the power of the squadristi on the streets. Both represented the power of the ras as leaders of regional factions of fascist groups. Historian [Alexander De Grand](#) writes:

"the old structures and mentality survived. Fascists merely became part of the existing system."

The [Acerbo Law](#) was passed as a kind of compromise, which gave two-thirds of the seats in Parliament to the party with 25% of the vote. That meant that the fascists could easily control Parliament while not having an outright majority. Elections did continue, but became a farce. Organized intimidation and violence stopped opposition from standing.

And slowly, Mussolini castrated Parliament and replaced it with the Fascist Grand Council. But this took many more years, and the King was still left in place. Italy then, while effectively fascist, was in reality a bit of a mongrel state between liberalism, constitutional monarchy and fascism. Mussolini for a while didn't have the confidence to go the whole mile. But in practice and in fact, Mussolini was supreme leader. It was a fascist state.

What we can see in both Germany and Italy are these kinds of shadow institutions. The squadristi and the SA, the Brownshirts, and the different leaders, and the main leadership rising up as paramilitary groups, blending in some ways with existing institutions and people and ideas, and then justified by crisis and legitimized by conservatives who compromised with them. The old liberal institutions and fascist power blend together until the latter — the fascists — eventually replaces the former entirely.

The spark that convinces conservatives to do this, usually cynically and hesitantly, is a crisis or a deep fear of the left, of what's going to happen. In key moment after key moment,

conservatives fearful of crisis and hopeful of a return to the good old, old ways enabled fascists.

In Italy, police and courts prosecuted the left and ignored the crimes of the right. And in Germany, patriotic crimes like Hitler's were given unusually short sentences.

The ultimate example of a crisis catapulting conservatives to enable fascists was the [Reichstag fire](#). Remember, Hitler had been appointed by Hindenburg in January of 1933, and in February of that year, a young vagabond, nobody anarchist burnt down the Reichstag in a lone act of protest.

Hitler was said to have responded:

"This is the beginning of the Communist uprising. Now we'll strike. There is not a minute to waste".

He rushed to Hindenburg, who signed a decree limiting the rights of the Constitution that read the following:

"Thus, restrictions on personal liberty and the right to free expression of opinion, including freedom of the press and the right of assembly and association, and violations of the privacy of postal, telegraphic and telephonic communications and warrants for house searches.

Orders for confiscations, as well as restrictions on property rights are permissible beyond the legal limits otherwise prescribed.

In a pen stroke, then, democracy had begun to be taken apart.

The Nazis and the police went through lists of communists and trade unionists, arrested, beat and tortured them, smashed their offices, took valuables. [10,000 people were arrested, and the party was banned entirely, an event called Great Purge.](#)

One stormtrooper remembered:

"We were prepared. We knew the intentions of our enemies. I put together a small mobile squad of my storm from the most daring of the daring. We lay in wait. Night after night. We were going to strike the first blow. And then it came — the beacon in Berlin. Signs of fire all over the country. Finally, the relief of the order. Go to it! And we went to it. It was not just about the purely human. You or me. You or us. It was about wiping the lecherous grin off the hideous, murderous faces of the Bolsheviks for all time and protecting Germany from the bloody terror of unrestrained hordes."

A quote that's a great example of the leadership from above, and the street forces rising up from below, meeting in the middle.

[Rudolf Diels](#), the first head of the Gestapo, wrote: Every SA man was on the heels of the enemy. Each knew what to do. The storm squads cleaned up the districts. They knew not

only where their enemies lived. They had also long ago discovered their hideouts and meeting places. Not only the communists, but anybody who had ever spoken out against Hitler's movement was in danger.

There was one final obstacle. The Reichstag. There was one more [election in March](#). The Nazis, now funded by industrialists, won more votes, but still not an absolute majority. But with the communists banned, intimidated and arrested, and by threatening, bribing and negotiating with the center parties, the Nazis found the numbers to get that two-thirds of the vote required to change the Weimar Constitution. Democracy was on its last legs.

In March 1933, [the Enabling Act](#) passed through the Reichstag and enabled Hitler to rule by decree, effectively abolishing parliament. Goebbels celebrated. He wrote in his diary:

"The road to the total state. A revolution has an uncanny dynamism."

⚡ **Democracy was dead.**

Chapter Thirteen: The Soul of Fascism

There's something we haven't talked about yet, but we definitely shouldn't forget. Money. There has for quite a long time been a kind of trope that fascism is, in the communist [Geforgi Dimitrov](#)'s phrase, the, quote, open terrorist dictatorship of the most reactionary, most chauvinistic and most imperialist elements of finance capital, unquote. That fascism is part of class struggle, an expression of the will of big corporations, big money, big capital.

The argument comes in different forms, but often has three parts: that anti-Bolshevism was a driving force, if not the driving force; that both Hitler and Mussolini sought to rationalize or corporatize or syndicalize the economy, but ended up leaving it mostly alone to capitalists; and crucially, that big business supported both regimes.

But there are problems with this interpretation. First, big business openly preferred traditional conservatives until they had no choice, a bit later on. Most of the Nazis' early funding came from small contributions and party membership dues, not from big capital. And finally, some industrialists were nervous about the socialist part of National Socialism, even if it was a front, even if the reforms ended up being hollow.

This is a big topic to get into, but my own view is that you can acknowledge the influence — and massive influence — of big capital and the bourgeoisie without being reductionist about it being the only defining factor. In other words, there's a lot going on. Many of the trends we've looked at — racism and anti-Semitism in particular — obviously predate capitalism. Plus, the anti-rationalism, the Völkisch thought, the Darwinism, the colonialism, the desire for order and so on are all driven by psychological, social, cultural and intellectual forces that can't just be reduced to economics. Even if economics is a major driving force.

My own view is usually that economics is central, but not the only factor. To take one example, the historian Fritz Stern writes that a thousand teachers in republican Germany who in their youth had worshiped [Lagarde or Langbehn](#) were just as important in the triumph of National Socialism as all the putative millions of marks that Hitler collected from German tycoons.

But Hitler did collect those millions from those tycoons. Some, like media magnate and [Krupp steelworks](#) director and nationalist [Alfred Hugenberg](#), hated Marxism but wasn't anti-Semitic, and he thought Hitler was too fanatical and potentially a socialist. Ironically. But someone like [Fritz Thyssen](#), the steel manufacturer, enthusiastically supported Hitler early on.

[In 1933, IG Farben, Deutsche Bank, a mining industry association, along with many others organized by the industrialist Gustav Krupp, who led the main German weapons manufacturer, raised a substantial amount of money for the Nazis.](#) Like, you might say, they only did that in 1933 out of fear when it was too late. But they did, of course, still do it. They weren't giving that money to the Social Democrats.

And when you combine this with middle-class bourgeois support, it's hard not to see it as a variation on the theme of imperialism as the highest form of capitalism. By the 1930s, the Nazis were better funded than both the Social Democrats and the communists.

But again, with all that said, there are the psychological, the social, the racist, the Darwinist, or quote unquote scientific factors, and the anti-rationalism too. So we should always warn against simplifying.

The sociologist [Seymour Lipset](#) called fascism an extremism of the center, a revolt of bourgeois shopkeepers and artisans and the middle classes against both big capital at first — or the image of the financial Jew — and the proletariat, or the Bolshevik threat from the left. And the Nazis found their early support mostly in that core of the Venn diagram.

But while money obviously permeates everything, it isn't everything. Culture, ideas, charisma, science, Darwin, religion, racism — they all sit alongside it, with it, being influenced by it. Yes, but it's not a one-to-one, simple, unidirectional thing.

And there's also that most fundamental thing that's permeated our entire story. The blunt force of violence.

After the Nazis came to power, Evans writes that:

"the terror was comprehensive in scope. The Nazis called it coordination. In the civil service, one German remembers, quote, swastika badges were already sprouting from the earth like mushrooms after a few days."

Which is our final ingredient in making a fascist — fear and power, conformity and propaganda.

We too often think of people brainwashed by propaganda and fear and tyranny and the desire to conform with their neighbors. But that's not what happened. This was a bottom-up, real, thoughtful, self-justifying movement with true, powerful, convincing, fundamental roots. That's what you have to think through to understand the core of fascism.

What we're interested in is the fascist core — the fascist heart, spirit or soul. Maybe in a way, I like to think of myself like a cooking channel. I want to show you the ingredients. These ingredients might go by other names in history. Factors, conditions, drivers, historical forces, or simple causes. But I quite like ingredients because, like a cooking channel, I've tried to show you the core basics and it's up to you how you interpret them, the weights you give them, the things you think I've missed. It's up to you to put it all together with everything else you know in your head.

But the ingredients at the heart of fascism, the fascist minimum as it's been called — fascism has been endlessly debated by historians. Let's quickly go through our ingredients.

The spiritualizing or heightening of violence. Anti-rationalism, a reaction to the Enlightenment. Heroism and action over religious debate or thought. Myth and story over rationalism and materialism. Vulgar or Social Darwinism, the scientism of struggle. Ultra-nationalism and Völkisch thought as a crisis of capitalism and liberalism. Authority and order over freedom and chaos. Anti-Bolshevism or anti-universalism. Paramilitarism. The reality and shock of World War One. And establishment support from big money and big politicians.

This becomes quite a list, and it risks fascism becoming that thing that you can't define, but you know when you see it.

The German historian [Ernst Nolte](#) came up with a six-point fascist minimum, which he listed as:

"anti-Marxism, anti-liberalism, anti-conservatism, the leadership principle, a party army, and the aim of totalitarianism."

And the philosopher and writer [Umberto Eco](#) came up with 14 — [The so-called, "Definitions of fascism"](#)

But maybe most influential, the historian [Roger Griffin](#) has described fascism quite tersely as:

"a palingenetic — which is a fancy word for rebirth, basically — form of populist ultra-nationalism."

To me, they fail to capture that very necessary thing that sets fascism apart from milder forms of authoritarianism — the drive, the energy for some kind of outer, inner expansion driven at heart by the heightening and spiritualization of violence. Violence has run through this story, and it's hard to see how fascism emerges in all of its dynamic, explosive, conservative radicalism without violence.

Remember John Foot's quote:

☞ "violence is a central theme."

I think fascism comes in a very large part from a fear of chaos. It is in some way, then, the ultimate form of ordering ideology. It's utopian in that it promises a special order, glory, a national belonging, a place, a leader, a good struggle, a clear enemy. It is a response to chaos, but it requires active participation, heroic violence to secure that ordered utopia.

Of course, there's something of the eternal, the universal or the transcendent, the timeless, in defining fascism in this way. Maybe it is part of that much broader genre. The struggle between freedom and power more generally. A new expression of the age-old emperor, the king, the tyrant, the master and the slave, the dominant and the dominated. That there is a total, a totalitarian idea that's lurked in history that bullies have been circling and trying to master for millennia, that it's an ever-present risk.

But it seems much more historical to write that it was of its moment, of its time, unrepeatable. That it was an anomaly. Historicizable. Containable.

Is this true? Because if it's part of an eternal threat, we could still be in for — not just for a repeat — but maybe for something worse. After all, democracy is no more historical than tyranny. Empires more common than republics. Monarchies and lords more frequent than liberalisms.

What does it mean to think about fascism today or fascism tomorrow? Well, I want to continue thinking about this question. So in the next articles, we're going to look at the ghosts of fascism. Why fascism remains in the public consciousness, what fascists did in power, and what that means for us today. Were they effective? Were they not? I want to look at the philosophy of fascism that still lives in texts eternally and still speaks to people. And I want to look at what the Nazis would have done if they had won, so that we can understand fascism in its ideal. But I also want to look at authoritarianism around the world today, what remains of the authoritarian vision for the world.

And then I've got a few ideas on the ghosts of fascism that kind of pulls it together, looks at fascists in power, and asks the question: why do the ghosts still linger? You know, were certain things effective in fascism? And that's why people still want to draw them from their graves. What's changed? What can we expect from a kind of neo-fascism or a neo-authoritarianism in the future? How will these things merge? History always moves. That's why we need to understand it, to try and think about what the picture will be tomorrow.

On Fascism – Kacper Patryk Sobczak

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